

Evaluating the Influence of Online Reviews on Gen Z and Younger Millennials' Purchase Decisions in Spain's Digital Retail Sector

Abstract

The growth of digital retail, consumer purchase behaviour is changing and online reviews are a key element of information during online shopping. This study aims to deepen the understanding of the impact of online reviews on the purchasing behaviour of Generation Z and younger Millennials for the online retail in Spain. In this research however focus is on the influence of the Internet-based reviews, credibility of these reviews, electronic word-of-mouth, whether realistic or fake, algorithmic recommendation systems as well as use of “influencer marketing” in the consumer trust, consumer purchase confidence and consumer purchasing behaviour. This research employed research method of Positivistic, Deductive research, Descriptive research and Quantitative Survey research strategy. This information was collected via a structured online questionnaire, carried out by convenience sampling and with a total of 100 user consumers belonging to the younger generations of the 2000s (with their own sample of Generation Z and younger Millennial). The data collected were analysed descriptively in terms of frequencies and percentages, the mean scores and graph in Ms Excel.

The results suggest that positive online reviews impact on purchase decisions, and that review credibility and consumer trust were the most significant factors when making purchase decisions. The objective mean scores of 3.94, 3.98 and 3.97 resulted in an overall grand mean of 3.96, which reflected overall agreement on the effects of digital information on consumer behaviors. The study also revealed that fake reviews erode consumer trust, whereas algorithmic options and the marketing by the people they respect actually shape the purchasing decisions – only if they are perceived as authentic and credible. The results of the study confirm the Social Proof Theory along with the Consumer Trust Theory and Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) Model, as it showed how consumer trust is the important mechanism between the provision of digital information and the purchase of the product. The study helps explain the behaviour of online purchases by younger consumers in Spain and offers some actionable insights for digital retailers about how they can enhance the credibility, transparency, and trust of reviews in order to thrive in the competitive e-commerce landscape.

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Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Introduction

Digital retailing has changed how people obtain information, evaluate items and make purchases in an incredible method. Consumers have immediate access to a vast amount of product information, such as using the internet, their smartphone or ecommerce websites, before purchasing (Rosário and Raimundo, 2021). In this setting, customer-generated experiences are found to be a driver that alleviates uncertainty, helps to evaluate products and increase purchase confidence (Ismagilova et al., 2020; Wang et al., 2023). Thus, reviews have become more than a mere feedback loop they are powerful tools that affect consumer knowledge, attitudes and actions. Investigating Generation Z and younger Millennials is a particular focus, as they are experiencing digital time at an extreme amount. The younger Millennials and Generation Z are especially relevant due to their extensive digital time. Such consumers are often consumers involved in online communities, online reviews or social media and peer recommendation when assessing products and services (Sánchez-Franco and Rey-Tienda, 2024). Peer produced content can also be more compelling than traditional advertising as this is not a direct promotional message, but a report of consumer experiences instead (Djafarov and Bowes, 2021).

It becomes a more prominent factor in the steadily growing e-commerce market in Spain (Statista 2025). There is more content among the consumers' journey to purchase that is coming from consumers online reviews, influencers, and algorithm recommendations. While all these solutions enhance the discovery of products, it does bring in concerns related to information overload and information review manipulation/transparency (Martínez Otero, 2021). The positive effect of online reviews on trust and purchase intention is still strong (Hsieh and Li, 2020; Ismagilova et al., 2020), but with many degrees of significance with relationship to credibility, authenticity and relevance. The discussion of the challenges caused by digital trust is starting to occur in other domains of algorithmic and influencer recommendations (Calvano et al., 2025; Ebrahimi et al., 2023). This research thus seeks to analyse the effect of reviews, eWOM and fake reviews, and the influence of the influencers and algorithmic recommendations on the trust in the construction processes and purchasing behaviour of younger people specifically in Spain.

1.2 Research Aim

The purpose of this research work is to assess the impact of online feedback on the buying decision in the Spanish e-commerce industry with special reference to the 'Generation Y' and younger 'Millennial' generations. The study also examines the nature of interaction between the factors with focus on the consumer's confidence in the review and consumer's trust, as well as the effect of review credibility on the consumer's confidence in the review, the importance of electronic word of mouth (eWOM) and fake reviews, the role of influencers marketing and algorithmic recommendation system on the consumer's confidence in the review and thus on the consumer's trust and their purchasing decision.

1.3 Research Questions

The study has the aim to give answer to the following research questions:

RQ1: How does online reviews affect their online shopping behavior in Spain with respect to Generation Z and younger generation of Millennials?

RQ2: In the case of Spain, is the credibility of the degree of review influencing the younger consumers' trust and purchase confidence from EWOM?

RQ3: What is the impact of fake reviews, influencer marketing and algorithmic based recommendation systems in the context of e-commerce on consumer's trust and buying decisions in the Spain context?

1.4 Research Hypotheses

These hypotheses are based on theories found in literature, which are then situated in the middle of the hypotheses that have been theorised thus far:

Key findings: H1: Positive online reputation can have a profound positive effect on purchase intentions of the younger 'Millennials' and Generation Z in Spain.

The conclusion is that there is a significant positive effect for review credibility to consumer trust. The positive impact of EWOM on the consumer's intention to buy the product and his/her trust in the company.

It is hypothesized that an increase in consumer trust will lead to an increase in purchase intention and purchasing behaviour. H4: Consumer trust is positively related to the purchase intention and purchasing behaviour.

H5: Fake reviews have had a negative effect on consumer's trust and purchasing confidence in the products that they are sold.

The hypothesis states that younger consumers will be more positively influenced by the influencer if/d then when brand marketing influences their purchase.

1.5 Research Objectives

The following are the objectives that will be adopted when achieving the research aim:

- To design a study to understand how influential internet reviews are for their Spanish Generation Z / younger Millennials' buying decisions.
- Assess the relationship between the credibility of the customer reviews, eWOM and consumer trust relationships.
- To be aware of the effect that the fake reviews have on their customer's (or viewer's) trust and buying decision.
- To gather a picture of the cost of marketing's impact on the younger consumers' purchase intent levels.
- To investigate the effects of algorithmic recommendation systems on the choice of products users make.

1.6 Background of the Study

Digital channels are ongoing and becoming even more relevant in consumers' buying process regarding digital sources of information. Since technological advances in recent years combined with the ubiquity of the Internet and consumers' behavior in recent times, which has been increasingly online, the ecommerce sector in Spain has also undergone strong growth (CNMC, 2024). Internet reviews are especially important to younger consumers as they give them information about the experiences of other consumers (Ismagilova et al., 2020). Social media, influencers and information algorithms have also expanded the space of information shaping consumer purchasing, at the same time. While these developments offer ease and convenience to access information and reviews, it raises concerns regarding the authenticity of reviews and information and transparency (Martínez Otero, 2021). For this reason, the effect on consumers'

perceptions and attitudes towards online consumption reviews has gained in relevance in the world of online retailing in Spain.

1.7 Research Rationale

The number of gaps in the research is a justification for the objectives and problem of this study. Firstly, while there have been vast studies on the influence of online reviews on customer behaviour there is lack of research that considers both these variables in tandem to identify the combined impact of these two variable on consumer trusts and decisions to purchase the product (Handoyo, 2024). Second, many of the previous studies focused on the domestic markets in the North-American and Asian markets, while the fast growing digital retail in Spain has few data. (Rosário and Raimundo, 2021). The third is their very low visibility particularly if they are 'Generation Z' and younger Millennials, who are among the most active digital consumers to date. Of course, last but not least, only limited research is available, that in theory combines the theories of Social Proof Theory and Consumer Trust Theory to explain the influence of a combination of digital information sources on the purchasing behaviour. These gaps will contribute to provide a bigger coverage of the consumer behaviour of the e-retailing industry in Spain.

1.8 Research Problem

The explosion of digital retailing, consumers are more dependent than ever on online reviews, electronic word-of-mouth, influencers and algorithms to help inform their buying choices. However, digital information sources both inform consumers about products and decrease the uncertainty of consumers, but as fake reviews and sponsored reviews have increased in addition to the algorithm-driven content, questions have been raised about the credibility, transparency and trustworthiness of digital information sources (Ebrahimi et al., 2023).

Although the effect of online reviews on consumers' purchasing intention has already been reported, there has been a lack of research focussing on quantifying and understanding the relationship between multiple online factors and the consumer's relationship with the brand, their trust and willingness to pay money in the Digital retail channel in the Spanish case. Furthermore, and crucially, little research dealing specifically with Generation Z and younger Millennials has surfaced; they are so reliant on digital sources of information that there is very little literature specifically geared toward them. The general research question is: What is the relationship between impact of consumer trust and buying behaviors of younger Spanish consumers?

1.9 Significance of the Study

This study makes its own contribution to academia due to its extension of the knowledge on online reviews, consumer trust and purchasing behaviour in the digital retail environment in Spain. It also offers some solutions to the theoretical gaps, which merges multiple digital influence factors into one.

The results can be leveraged by the industry for better review management, influencer marketing and/or trust building mechanism. Based on the results, one may be able to develop policies and/or standards on transparency and algorithmic accountability pertaining to fake reviews and misleading endorsements. In the end, the study might foster younger awareness regarding the customers and inspire them to create better choices as they purchase and use digital platforms in the society.

1.10 Structure of the Dissertation

This dissertation is in six chapters.

In Chapter One, there is an introduction of the research topic/question, research aim, research objectives, research problem, research hypotheses, Research Rationale and the significance of the study.

The literature of the subject centered on Online Rewards, eWOM, consumer trust, fake reviews and influencer marketing/algorithmic recommendation system is conducted a critical review in Chapter Two. Theoretical aspects and the concept bases are also discussed.

The research methodology, which covers the research philosophy, approach, design, data collection technique and sampling strategy as well as ethical considerations are presented in Chapter Three.

A research designed to answer the question “Results” is presented in Chapter Four.

The results have been discussed and interpreted in the light of literature and theories in Chapter Five.

A summary of the important finding, implication, limitation and suggestions for future research of the investigation are summarized in chapter six.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

Digital technologies have revolutionised consumers' spending and purchasing habits, impacting the retail industry in all markets around the world. The new growing power of

Since the introduction of e-commerce platforms, social media, mobile commerce apps, and user-generated content, thus consumers' information acquisition and evaluation process prior to purchase decisions has been altered. In particular, in this digital age, online reviews have become an important source of consumer-generated information, which may provide real-time information about past experiences and reviews by consumers (Ismagilova et al., 2020).

Online reviews are gaining significance, especially for younger generations like Generation Z, as they increasingly turn to online sources of information during the buying decision-making process. These consumers are typically active on social media platforms, online forums, review websites and in influencer communities during purchase decisions, in contrast with the previous generation (Migkos et al., 2025). In fact, the impact of online reviews goes further than just giving information, as they are increasingly playing a big part in consumer's trust, confidence and buying decisions.

Although most studies have shown that consumers are more often than not influenced by online reviews, these results indicate that the connection between the two is more nuanced than first believed. So although one might find credible reviews useful to lessen uncertainty and foster trust, it has become more and more common these days to find fake reviews, sponsored reviews, reviews created by algorithms, and reviews from “influencers”, which has lead to questions about the transparency and authenticity (Martínez Otero, 2021; Ebrahimi et al., 2023). Consequently, modern digital consumers need to assess the credibility of sources of information as well as reviews, and not just their content.

In terms of raising these concerns there is no better example that could be found anywhere other than the Spanish digital retail market. Over the last 10 years, Spain has seen significant development in the e-commerce sector, driven by increased Internet penetration, digital innovations, and changing consumer preferences (CNMC, 2024). In the meantime, reviews of products on the Internet and recommendations from social media are highly influential when it comes to how younger Spanish consumers perceive products and services. There is, however, limited research that has studied the influence of the combined-effects of credibility of reviews,

electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), influencer marketing, fake reviews and algorithmic recommendation mechanisms on the purchasing behaviour of Generation Z and younger Millennials in Spain.

Hence, this chapter critically reviews the literature relating to consumer behaviour and online reviews within a digital retail environment. It looks at the evolution of digital retail in Spain, the impact of electronic word of mouth, consumers' decision making processes, the theoretical foundations of consumer behaviour, review credibility, consumers' trust, influencer marketing, fake reviews and algorithmic recommendation systems. Finally, the chapter presents the major theoretical and research gaps, which warrant the present research study.

2.2 Digital Retail Sector and Online Reviews in Spain

2.2.1 Growth of Digital Retail in Spain

Spain's digital retail sector has expanded rapidly because of technological advancement, widespread internet access and improvements in digital payment systems, accelerating the growth of e-commerce and changing consumer purchasing behaviour (Statista, 2025). Consumers have become more demanding when it comes to their expectations in an online environment, as they want it to be convenient, competitive and available, along with providing reliable information before buying (Rosário and Raimundo, 2021). This has transformed e-commerce into a space that is packed with information that allows consumers to make comparisons, read reviews, and, in doing so, lower purchase uncertainty. Because of the lack of human interaction when making online purchases, external sources like reviews, ratings, and product recommendations are relied upon more for their insights and help with making a purchasing decision (Ventre and Kolbe, 2020). Positive reviews build consumer's confidence in the brand and product and negative or manipulated reviews can make it less desirable for the buyer and lowers the credibility of the brand/organisation (Wang et al., 2023).

2.2.2 Online Reviews and Electronic Word-of-Mouth (eWOM)

Online reviews are a vital type of EWOM, allowing their users to quickly share their experience and recommendations with others, via a digital platform (Ismagilova et al., 2020). As per the previous research, eWOM affects consumer information asymmetry and boosts consumers'

purchase confidence (Ismagilova et al., 2020) and affects consumers both informational and social-wise (Wang et al., 2023). But there are questions still left unanswered about its veracity as a review. While customer-generated reviews are believed to be more credible than business-provided advertising (Li & Park, 2019; Hsieh & Li, 2020), fake reviews and paid endorsements make consumers distrust customer reviews (Ebrahimi et al., 2023). Social problems, especially with regard to Generation Z and the younger Millennials, are also very relevant due to their high dependence on digital information in the decision-making process while purchasing items (Sánchez-Franco and Rey-Tienda, 2024).

2.3 Consumer Buying Behaviour

2.3.1 Digital Consumer Decision-Making

Consumer buying behaviour refers to the process of searching for information, evaluating alternatives, making purchase decisions and assessing products after purchase (Kotler and Keller, 2022). This process is more complex in digital retail practices as within their purchasing process, digital consumers interact with various resources including online reviews, ratings, social media, recommendations, personalised advertising, etc. (Pradhan et al., 2023). Online reviews help eliminate information asymmetry, as they give evaluations of the corporation via former client reviews that decrease the perceived possibility and assist customers with informed selections (Fileri et al., 2021). Nevertheless, Web purchases may result in information overload, making purchasing decisions harder instead of easier (Handoyo, 2024). Thus, the effectiveness of online reviews relies on the quality, relevance and credibility of the reviews. Consumer trust is also crucial since online shoppers don't have the opportunity to physically test the products that they are looking to acquire. Rather than aiming based on the trustworthy digital information, they assess the quality and reliability of the products (Abou Ali et al., 2020). Thus, in addition to information, people's attitude toward purchasing online is influenced by the credibility of reviewers besides the level of consumer trust.

2.3.2 Generation Z and Younger Millennials

The internet generations (Y Generation or Generation Z) and younger Millennials are a large area of digital consumers and in the past and present they have been accustomed to using the internet, mobile technologies and social media more than ever in their daily lives (Migkos et al., 2025). Therefore, they heavily depend on online reviews, their buying decisions, and social media recommendations/ influencers' content generated products (Djafarova and Bowes, 2021). Though these consumers are seen as being digitally knowledgeable, they can still be persuaded by the content they see, as well as from influencer marketing (Sahai et al., 2024). In addition, a younger consumer's preference for authenticity, transparency and social validation (ATSV) while choosing products and brands is also found in the research. The research also found that youth market is more and more evaluating qualities of authenticity, transparency and social validation when making product and brand choices. Thus, it is argued that the weight of the reviews (received by customers) can become an even more critical factor than amount of reviews, when consumers consider the trustworthiness of information when determining their purchase. This tendency is especially noticeable in terms of younger Spanish consumers who tend to interact with social media and digital platforms while making their purchases (Sánchez-Franco et Rey-Tienda, 2024). They are therefore crucial to explain how they act when it comes to purchasing, and hence the importance of understanding the factors that set out to build trust.

2.4 Theoretical Foundations

2.4.1 Social Proof Theory

The concept of Social Proof Theory was derived from Naeem, 2021 where people tend to follow what others do and to think like them in deciding what to do when there is uncertainty. In online retail shops, internet reviews are an instance of social proof, as they offer proof about the encounters and assessments of past customers.

The theory has been used to explore online consumers' behaviour in great detail since these sets of functionalities can influence the perceived quality of products and affordability of their purchase (Ventre and Kolbe, 2020). Positive opinions could convey the reliability of the product and build up the purchase behaviour and when a negative opinion, it may make purchaser uncertain whether

to purchase the product. In this way, consumer's choices are impacted by on-line reviews by giving them social proof.

These days, the platforms are inundated with either fake ones or sponsored ones, or even with ones that have been written by computers (Salminen et al., 2022), while the old social proof relies upon the fact that the opinions of the people are sincere based upon their real experience. As a result consumers might be doubtful about the value of the genuine social data. This restriction suggests that solely by assessing social proof, it is difficult to visualize the nature of contemporary digital buyer's behavior; in this context, the building of trust should also be seen as a consideration.

2.4.2 Consumer Trust Theory

Consumer Trust Theory highlights the relationship between consumers and organisations, and states that: “Trust reduces uncertainty and enables and or removes obstacles to exchange relationships between consumers and organisations” (Rashidi-Sabet & Bolton, 2024). In online consumer transactions, trust assumes special importance as consumers may not be in contact with product and retailers.

Trust was previously determined to have positive correlations with its purchase intention and satisfaction and customer loyalty (Hsieh & Li, 2020). Credibility of information drives consumers to trust the retailers and therefore, to make an actual purchase. Concurrently, any concerns about misinformation or manipulation might cause a loss of trust and reduce transactional activity.

It has been agreed that trust is a vital ingredient of trust but there is still a debate as to what are most likely to facilitate trust. While a few studies focus mainly on the quality and credibility of the reviews, others stress the importance of platform reputation, platform source expertise or social influence as key factors (Wang et al., 2023). To the extent that the understanding of trust can be treated as a multidimensional phenomenon, this can lead to the belief that various formats of online information have an impact. Based on these two, the theory of the consumer trust comes as a crucial theory to understand the online review and consumer purchasing behaviour.

2.4.3 Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) Theory

The Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) Theory by Cheng et al, (2024) is another theoretical approach of consumer behaviours in a digital retail store that will be discussed. According to this

theory, there is an outside world (the event) which affects internal (psychological) states that in turn affect behavior.

For the purpose of this case study, online reviews, credibility of reviews and fake online reviews were taken as an exogenous stimulus as were eWOM and fake eWOM, algorithmic based recommendation systems and influencer marketing. The SOR framework strength is that it offers a single theoretical framework to grasp the interaction of several factors related to the Digital. It's not only the Social Proof Theory and Consumer Trust Theory consensus: It's the consensus through the lens of the theory revealing the relationship of external information sources to the consumer's internal evaluation prior to consumer behaviour. The relation of the theory developed are relevant to the relationships examined and is important to be discussed.

In addition, the SOR model is gaining popularity in recent research in digital marketing as it has been acknowledged as the complexity of the online decision-making process and psychological factors influencing consumer behavior (Amarullah et al., 2022).

2.5 Review Credibility, Consumer Trust and Purchase Intention

2.5.1 Review Credibility

Review credibility is when consumers believe online reviews are accurate, reliable and trustworthy (Filieri et al., 2021). Credibility is becoming more important with readers in the digital landscape when they are not "touching" the product, but instead relying on content as their information source. Thus, it is not just the volume of reviews needed to be provided, but the perception of authenticity of the reviews that must be provided. Likewise, Hsieh and Li (2020) believe that balanced reviews with detailed customer experiences are more credible and Filieri et al. (2021) suggest that quality and reviewer expertise/Objectivity of the review has a greater impact on credibility. But, there are discrepancies between studies with regards to what factors are used to judge credibility.

Ventre, Kolbe (2020) propose that popularity implies credibility with more reviews, while Salminen, et al. (2022) state that too many reviews can lead to less trust if they are perceived as unoriginal or manipulated. The results of both of these opposing statements are especially important for Generation Z and younger Millennials, who actively consume information quality when deciding to purchase (Osman and Ying, 2022).

2.5.2 Consumer Trust

The trust of the consumer is a significant factor in shape of consumer responses for purchasing activities in digital environment due to its reducing uncertainty and enhancing consumer confidence during online transaction activities (Choudhuri et al.,2024). Online shoppers are heavily reliant upon information to make the quality decisions and to make reliable assessments of retails. The previous research studies all show that there is a positive correlation between credible reviews and formation of trust. As many studies indicated (Wang et al., 2023; Abou Ali et al., 2020), the online trust is a critical element that boosts consumers' confidence in product and retailer. But, which factors are the most important determinants of trust are not agreed upon by scholars. Some say that credibility of their reviews is important in consumer trust while others say that it is platform reputation, social media interaction and quality of their websites (Handoyo, 2024). In addition, algorithm-driven suggestions, paid advertising and influencer advertising have made digital trust to be more complex for the audience as they have to take the quality of the content into consideration, besides the commercial motivation associated with it (Sahai et al., 2024). Leading this is Spain's digitally active consumer market and this is a very relevant challenge for it.

2.5.3 Purchase Intention

It is often believed that purchase intention is an indicator of actual purchase behaviour and is considered as a significant one since customers may think about buying a product or service in the future when they demonstrate high purchase intention (Kotler and Keller, 2022). A study in the past has clearly showed that online reviews impact purchase intention positively as they help in diminishing uncertainty and bring confidence while making purchases. Consumer trust can be reinforced and purchasing behaviour can be triggered by positive reviews (Ismagilova et al., 2020), and the quality of a review can boost the perceived value and product attractiveness (Pradhan et al., 2023). But there is a gray zone as regards this relation. Ebrahimi et al. (2023) have suggested that the impact of positive reviews diminishes if consumers suspect these to be manipulated while Salminen et al. (2022) have indicated that online trust's effects on purchase intentions are reduced when consumers trust that online reviews are manipulated. Review valence thus is not solely responsible for the purchase intention but also depends on the review's credibility and trust in the consumer. These relationships are crucial to grasp when discussing with them the buying habits of younger generations – and Generation Z.

2.6 Fake Reviews and Algorithmic Recommendation Systems

2.6.1 Fake Reviews

Fake opinions are evaluative statements that are designed to impact users understanding of goods, services or organisations, that aren't genuine (Martínez Otero, 2021). They pose a number of ethical and legal problems given that they decrease transparency and influence consumers' decision-making process (Martínez Otero, 2021). Building trust in the information available online and clearing up uncertainties when it comes to buying products, fake reviews have been found to have a negative effect in previous research (Salminen et al., 2022; Ebrahimi et al., 2023). But, there are differing opinions on the overall effect. Some claim the rise of digital expertise affords consumers the capacity to grasp fake consumer evaluates (Osman and Ying, 2022) whereas others put forth that AI generated faux reviews are tougher to perceive (Salminen et al., 2022). This makes it a challenge to digital retail today to have bogus reviews.

2.6.2 Algorithmic Recommendation Systems

Indeed, an algorithmic recommendations system has entered the picture, which helps consumers by offering personal product recommendations, thanks to a data track that is collected from consumers and analysed to devise their preferred and behavioural patterns (Calvano et al., 2025). Such systems have some advantages which are mentioned by Amarullah et al. (2022) are being able to filter information and making decision more efficiently and to enhance consumer satisfaction by offering product that are relevant to them. So, recommendation systems are seen as valuable “decision support tool systems” in the digital retail. The question on the other hand is the inexplicability of algorithms' predispositions, consumers' autonomy and transparency of processes. Proposals have been made to reinforce existing preferences and limit exposure to other products through algorithms for making these recommendations (May and Brach, 2025). The dilemmas as illustrated here are of the utmost importance that digital markets are not only fair, accountable and transparent, but that they are always.

2.6.3 Ethical Concerns

Digital technologies help connect people to information and make it easier to rely on these technologies for convenience, but they also provide the opportunity to manipulate or misinform (Martínez Otero, 2021). A significant ethical question exists around consumers being able to have confidence in which experiences are indeed their real experience vs those that commercial experience has influenced and over prioritised in the behaviour scores. This brings the issue of accountability of retailers and/or digital platforms to ensure accurate and transparent information. These are specific issues especially for the younger generation who are frequent invaders of digital content; reminding marketers the necessity of ethical and trusted online selling environments.

2.7 Influencer Marketing and Consumer Behaviour

2.7.1 The Role of Influencer Marketing in Digital Retail

Because influencers impact on consumer attitudes, trust and buying decisions via social media interaction (Djafarova and Bowes, 2021), the marketing strategies of influencing have become an important aspect of digital retail. Studies indicate that when a brand can draw in a genuine influencers' feed, it pumps up their involvement and positive brand perceptions, especially in the case of youth consumers (Pradhan et al., 2023). Consumers' trust and purchase intentions also increase when influencers are credible (Shamim & Islam, 2022) and the product demonstration and personal experiences decrease the purchase uncertainty (Sokolova and Kefi, 2020). While influencer marketing is important for gaining the attention of consumers towards products generally, the degree of commercialisation may also lower the authenticity and trust of consumers (Dowd and DeLay, 2021; Yildiz et al., 2022; Ozza and Berti, 2021; Osman, 2022; Osman and Ying, 2022). ESPNET (Spain) (Duarte, Kuayeng and Chaparro, 2016) affirm that the typical consumer profile in Spain is young people who are concerned with these aspects, which is why they will be of great importance among the younger segment of society.

2.7.2 Influence on Generation Z and Younger Millennials

The younger generation of Millennials and Generation Z are active users of social media when seeking information and buying products and is where influencer marketing becomes very

important to these consumers (Migkos et al., 2025). In the case of authentic and trustworthy influencer-generated content, consumers seem to be more engaged and more likely to make a purchase (Casalo et al., 2020). When included in the communicative process, social identification stimulates consumers to accept influencers' preferences and behaviours (Jin and Ryu, 2020). Likewise, consumers' attitudes towards a brand and consumer purchase intent is affected by positive influencer endorsement (Schouten et al., 2021). Conversely, if there is too much commercialisation, the perceived authenticity and trust is lowered in the influencer and his/her effectiveness is limited (Djafarova & Bowes, 2021). Hence, the main influence in purchases based on an influencer marketing is its authenticity, expertise, transparency and confidence.

2.8 Critical Literature Analysis

Prior studies show that reviews do affect consumer trust, purchases intentions and purchase behaviour, but there are a number of important debates to be explored. Initially, the presence of online reviews can have a positive impact on a customer's willingness to purchase (Ismagilova et al., 2020; Wang et al., 2023), and if the customer becomes aware of fake reviews, it could lead to decreased positive influence (Ebrahimi et al., 2023), meaning that the credibility of the review is more relevant than its availability within the online environment. Second, it is not easy to form a trust. According to some studies, review credibility is the key factor for trust (Hsieh & Li, 2020) while other studies focus on platform reputation, reviewer expertise and social influence (Handoyo, 2024). Third, influencer marketing has a positive impact on the purchase behaviour (Migkos et al., 2025), but the questions of what sponsored content effect is and how it could be more authentic bring into question its sustained relevance as an effective marketing strategy (Osman and Ying, 2022). Finally, there are concerns about algorithmic bias and consumer autonomy as well as concerns regarding transparency, while recommendation systems improve personalisation (Mounib et al., 2022). In general, these factors have been previously studied individually, and an integrated approach in digital consumer behaviour is needed.

2.9 Research Gap

First of all, the majority of the studies introduce a territorial treatment in North America and Asia, when the digital retail sector in Spain has grown massively (Rosário and Raimundo, 2021), although the available evidence is still limited. Second, Gen Z and younger Millennials are

underrepresented, yet one of the most active online grocers (Migkos et al., 2025). Thirdly, the theories used in previous research are usually used independently, which offer partial understanding of how the integration of multiple theories can explain digital purchasing behaviour. As a result, the integration of Social Proof Theory, Consumer Trust Theory and the SOR framework, is thus filling an important gap in theory. Lastly, many previous investigations focus on one specific aspect of social media – such as online ratings or online influence or recommendation systems alone or on each others dimensions and impact each on its own – facially and not on the combined effect. Therefore the present study aims to analyze across a comprehensive integrated approach the internet reviews, the credibility of that review, eWOM, fake reviews and how the General Z and the younger Millennials trust and their purchasing behavior in Spain at the global level by examining all these variables together.

2.10 Conceptual Framework

Relationships between the variables proposed by the literature consulted and the theoretical bases showed that some online reviews, online review credibility, eWOM, influence marketing, fake online review and algorithmic recommendation system will serve as the main independent variables that will influence consumers' purchasing behavior and trust.

The theory behind which the framework is based is the concept called social proof, which are opinions and emotions people use to evaluate their decisions and feelings about uncertain conditions, others. Both theories provide complementary rational explanation as to why and how consumers' trust needs to be tied with the information evaluation process to make a purchase decision, and how the external stimulus (digital) influence the psychological response (interpersonal) and the behaviour of the consumer.

In the scenario imagined, user trust may be compromised due to the reliability of the reviews, via electronic word of mouth, influencer marketing and fake reviews/recommendation systems. The trust of the consumer then has a positive on the intention to purchase and purchasing behaviour. Thus, trust becomes an integral mechanism that influences consumers' decision making of digital information. This perspective is described in terms of the hypotheses, as outlined in the first chapter, to which the empirical investigation of the next few chapters is directed.

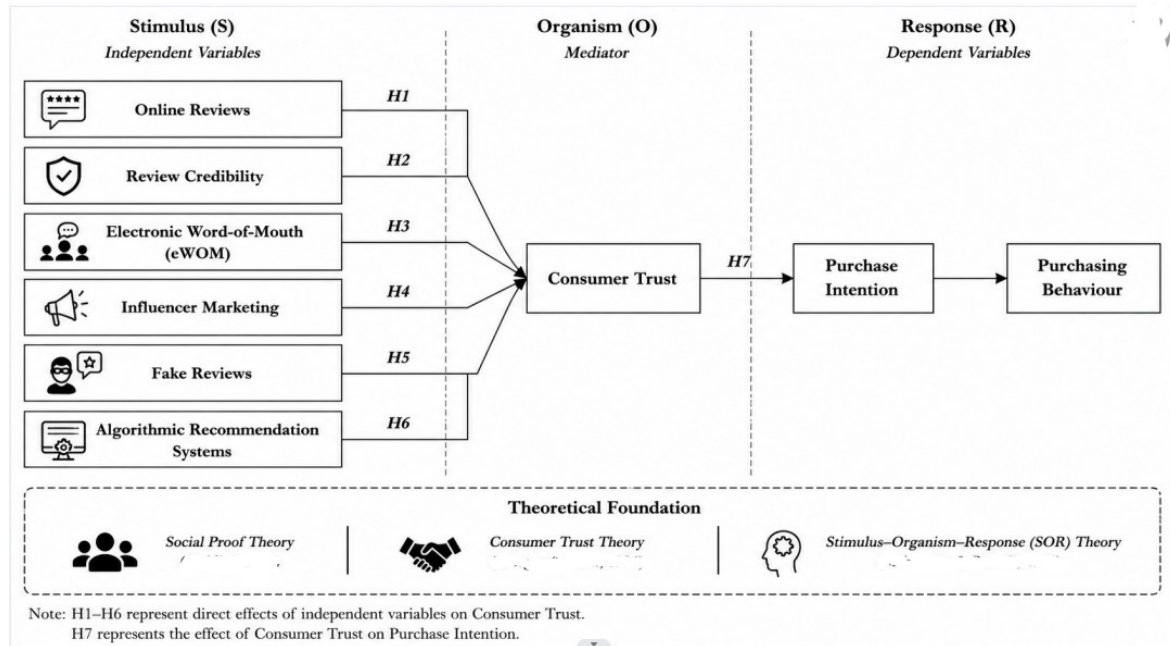


Figure 1: Conceptual Framework

(Source: Self Created)

2.11 Chapter Summary

This chapter did an in-depth literature review that covered the following areas: online reviews, electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), consumer buying behaviour, review credibility, consumer trust, fake reviews, and algorithmic recommendation systems within digital retail. The review highlighted that consumers' purchasing decisions in the online world are influenced by their trust of online reviews, namely younger people known as Millennials and Generation Z were identified, and concerns in relation to the credibility of the reviews and the authenticity of the influencers, as well as the non-disclosure of fake reviews and transparency towards the algorithm were raised. The chapter also laid down a theoretical framework for the study, which included Social Proof Theory, Consumer Trust Theory, Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR). Lastly, research gaps have been identified, arising from the aforementioned context, population and theoretical, methodological issues which justify the research undertaken in the present work and form the basis for the research methodology presented in Chapter 3.

Chapter 3: Methodology

3.1 Introduction

The methodology followed for the analysis of the effect of online reviews on the decision-making process of Generation Z and younger Millennials in the Spanish online retail sector is detailed in this chapter. It makes sense of the research methods chosen for the research aim and objectives stated in Chapter 1. A good methodology provides that the findings of the research are reliable, valid and suitable for solving the problem. As the study deals with a relationship between measured variables and consumer behaviour, quantitative methodology was opted for. The data has been gathered by means of an online questionnaire which has been sent to 100 young people between the ages of 18 and 24, belonging to the generation of Z or the younger generation of Millennials, in Spain. The themes noted during the literature review were used to develop the questionnaire. In this chapter, the research philosophy, research approach, research design, research strategy, data collection methods and analysis techniques is discussed in order to obtain the results that are consistent with the theoretical framework of the study.

3.2 Research Philosophy

Research philosophy is the set of beliefs and assumptions, and the ways of gathering, understanding and creating knowledge in a research work (Gamage, 2025). The choices of philosophy strongly impact on method choices and thus it is important for them to be chosen appropriately. In this study, a positivist research philosophy was used. According to positivism, social phenomena can be studied randomly in the realities of social and objective facts using measurable data (Ali, 2024). This study investigates the effect of online reviews, and other online related factors, on the online buying behaviour, and based on this, numerical data collected by using a structured questionnaire is a suitable tool for objective analysis. The study also pushes relationships theorized by social proof theory and consumer trust theory in performance such as online review, online review credibility, eWOM, consumer trust and consumer purchase intention. The quantitative method is a well-defined one that minimizes subjectivity by the researchers and aids in systematic analysis. The difficulty with interpretivism being chosen for study is that the

concept emphasizes subjective experiences using qualitative research, which was discarded. Thus, positivism gives the most solid method for testing the proposed hypotheses and based on the goal of the research.

3.3 Research Approach

Research Approach is the direction or logical sequence in which to move from theory to empirical work (Thomas & Thomas 2021). The deductive research approach was employed as it is an applied research method which involves testing theories based on empirical evidence. Due to these theories, and literature reviewed in Chapter 2 three research hypotheses have been formulated and tested via quantitative data from Spain's respondents. The deductive approach facilitates comparisons between the theoretical expectations and the findings in a situation or environment in which the applicability of certain theories can be evaluated in the context of digital retail in Spain. While an inductive approach was found to be useful, it was not suitable in this study because it is designed to derive new theories from the qualitative observations made. It should be noted that this research will test the theories of others and not develop new theories; therefore the deductive method is the most suitable and systematic to the achievement of research objectives.

3.4 Research Design

According to Creswell and Creswell (2023), research design is a research blueprint that outlines how the data for the research is gathered, measured, and analyzed for quality achievement of the research objective. This research type was descriptive research since it can be applied in describing consumer attitude, perception and behavior in the specified population. Descriptive research can be used to systematically measure variables without the researcher affecting the research environment (Hair et al., 2022). The study was appropriate, as the study's objective was to explore perceptions of online reviews, how too many reviews by the same publisher could affect their perceptions of 'reality,' the eWOM concept, consumer trust, fake reviews, algorithmic recommendation systems, and influencer marketing among younger Millennials and Generation Z in Spain. All the collected data were tested and trends/patterns were established in the behavior of consumer buying. Covering "exploratory research" was ruled out because the subject has already

been extensively studied in the previous research and explanatory research was ruled out since the study was not designed to deduce causality in the experimental way. Hence, descriptive research was the best framework in meeting the objectives of the research.

3.5 Research Strategy

Research strategy is how the data are gathered and analyzed to effectively resolve research questions (Taherdoost, 2021). This research used a survey approach since it is a commonly used research method to gather standardised information from many respondents. The survey allowed quantitative data to be gathered and included information on consumer's perceptions, attitudes and purchasing behavior towards online reviews and related digital factors. A structured questionnaire enabled that the participants answered the same questions, increasing the quality and comparability of the data in terms of both consistency and reliability. The survey method also followed the positivist philosophy and deductive method that facilitated measurement of the data for descriptive statistics and hypothesis testing. Interviews and focus groups were also investigated as alternative methods but not chosen due to their smaller sizes and higher level of researcher interpretation. As a consequence, the survey strategy proved to be the best approach to gather a reliable and comparable objective data from 100 Generation Z and younger Millennial consumers in Spain.

3.6 Data Collection Method

The present study used the primary data collection method, structured online questionnaires. Primary data is data gathered first-hand from the participants to be utilized in addressing a research problem (Doran et al., 2026). This approach was suitable since this study dealt with the effect of the online reviews on Generation Z and younger Millennials users' purchasing behavior in Spain. The research method of primary data collection allowed the researcher to be able to gather appropriate contemporary facts about the consumer attitudes, perception and experiences. The questionnaire was sent out via an online platform as it was well suited for the digital populous and offered benefits such as being cost-efficient, quick to collect, more geographically representative and senders found it easier to access the respondents. Chapter 2 (literature revue and conceptual framework) has informed development of questionnaire.

It covered the following: participant consent, questions about demographics, online review questions, questions about online purchasing, questions about credibility of online reviews, electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), consumer trust, fake reviews, algorithmic recommendation system, and influencer marketing questions. Both items 7-17 covered Objective 1 and 18-27 covered Objective 2—very close to the research objective/hypotheses and Questions 28-45 covered Objective 3.

3.7 Target Population

The target population consisted of the youngest Millennials (18-35) in Spain that do Internet shopping. This population was chosen as they are the target of this research and the study focuses on the impact online reviews has on purchase behavior within Spain's online retail market. Generation Z and younger Millennials are one of the most digital generation groups, relying on digital reviews, social media, eWOM and digital recommendations routinely in the purchasing process. The choice of Spain was made based on the fact that the overall digital consumer engagement and the rapid growth experienced by the eCommerce sector in the country were identified in the literature review. By concentrating focally on a single country, the results becomes more relevant to the changing context of digital retail in Spain. Children and the elderly less than 18 and more than 35 years old, respectively, were excluded from the study, in order to maintain consistency between the research aim, conceptual framework, questionnaire design and data analysis.

3.8 Sampling Technique and Sample Size

Sampling involves taking a part of a population for research to study (Doran et al., 2026). The data collection method used in this study was non-probability sampling approach, specifically convenience sampling, since the participants were easily accessible, and keen to participate in the study. This technique is well adopted in consumer behaviour research and guaranteed that consumers were willing to describe their experiences in online shopping transactions over the following year and online review systems. Stratified and simple random sampling methods have been given consideration, but they were abandoned as gaining access to a complete sampling frame

of eligible online consumers in Spain was impractical. The targeted respondents in this study were 100, which was deemed sufficient that it facilitates segregation of patterns and trends within the available resources (Casteel & Bridier, 2021). The chosen sample size was adequate to fulfil the research purposes and to analyze purchasing behaviour patterns in Generation Z and younger Millennials in Spain; even if a bigger one would enhance the statistical generalisability of the study, this was not intended to achieve the research goals.

3.9 Questionnaire Design

The questionnaire was structured and standardised aiming to gather quantitative data about the impact of Web 2.0 reviews on consumer buying choices. Structured questionnaires are very popular in quantitative research because of their ability to collect data systematically and facilitate quantitative analysis (Forza & Sandrin, 2023). The questionnaire had all closed questions and had no statements in which respondents had to give free answers; this eliminated any ambiguity in the gathering process of data. For most of the attitudinal items, the scale was 5 points ranging from “Strongly Disagree” to “Strongly Agree” which allowed for varying degrees of agreement and for quantitative analysis. The questionnaire consisted of the following: Demographics: age, gender, frequency of shopping, preferred online retail platforms, and items that are in ones' shopping cart. The literature review and the conceptual framework have been the bases for the development of the questionnaire, which directly relates to the research objectives, research questions and research hypotheses.

3.10 Pilot Testing

The questionnaire was pilot tested to check the clarity, structure and suitability prior to the main data collection. Pilot testing is one of the crucial phases in survey-based study, particularly because it assists to find out any potential drawbacks before conducting a full-scale data collection process (Sukserm, 2024). In the pilot study, 5 to 10 respondents were recruited having similar characteristics to target population. Participants filled out the questionnaire, and offered comments on question wording, clarity, structure and ease of understanding. As a result the researcher was able to identify questions that were not clear and was able to evaluate the suitability of the answer

choices and could estimate the time that was required for them to be completed (on average). The wording and/or format of the questions was modified slightly in response to feedback given in the pilot study. The improvements enabled a better yet clear research instrument in which there were less chances of misinterpretation and enhanced respondent experience. So the final questionnaire was taken to be reliable, easy to use and it could gather accurate and relevant data from the target population.

3.11 Data Analysis Technique

Data collected were analyzed by descriptive statistical techniques. Data analysis is a process that helps to organise, interpret and analyze data in answering research questions and testing research hypotheses (Alem, 2020). After the data collection, all the answers were coded, organised and analysed using Microsoft Excel. The chosen software was EXCEL, which has excellent abilities in calculating frequencies, percentages and summary statistics and is appropriate for tabulating and displaying tables and charts. To describe the characteristics of the respondents, frequency distribution and percentages were used to analyse demographic questions. For the purposes of answering Research Question 1 and Hypothesis 1, Questions 7–17 explored the impact that online reviews have on purchasing behaviour. For Research Question 2 and Hypothesis 2, questions 18–27 focused on the credibility of the reviews and Electronic Word-Of-Mouth and consumer trust. Research question 3 and hypothesis 3 were addressed through questions 28-45 that focused on fake reviews, algorithmic recommendation systems, digital ethics and influencer marketing. Table, chart and descriptive interpretation presented the findings which were related to the research objectives and theory reference.

3.12 Reliability and Validity

To ensure the quality and credibility of the results of the research work, you must ensure reliability and validity. Reliability is the consistency of research instrument and validity is the instrument to measure the concept being measured. Some further uniformity in responses was achieved by the use of closed-ended questions and a five point Likert scale. There was also one aspect of data collection which was streamlined online, namely online administration. The development of the

questionnaires was strengthened by literature link: the items cover concepts that could be measured on the aspects of 'reviews and review' credibility, e-tips-of-the-month, consumer trust, 'falses' reviews, algorithmic recommendation and influencer marketing. Therefore, content validity was further enhanced here by integrating it with the research objectives and the theoretical framework were used. The questionnaire was derived using face validity in the pilot testing process where the clarity and relevance of the questionnaire was assessed by the participants. The standardised administration, theory-based instrument development and pilot testing assures the overall reliability, validity and credibility of the research result.

3.13 Ethical Considerations

Ethical issues were monitored during the research process to comply with the research participants and maintaining the research integrity. The participants were voluntarily and only information regarding the purpose of the research was given to the respondents before the questionnaires were filled with. The informed consent of all participants was obtained, and each had the option of not participating, and to terminate participation from the time they responded. No personal information was gathered for the survey, so vulnerable respondents' confidentiality and anonymity were preserved. All answers were anonymous and for academic purposes. The collected data was restricted to the researcher only and no other person was allowed to use that or disclose it without due approval. Observing standard of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) was also implemented during the study by securing data stores and responsibly managing information during research. Such ethical processes safeguarded participant rights, fostered transparency, ensured responsible data management, and strengthened the research findings' credibility, integrity and ethical quality.

3.14 Methodological Limitations

The results presented have to be interpreted with due consideration of a few methodological constraints. The following is potential limitation, namely sampling bias since a convenience sampling was employed (which was not necessarily random sampling). This may lead to non-representative samples of Spanish young people's total population (the younger Millennials and

Generation Z). Second, it was a self reported study (questionnaire); there is the potential for recall error and personal and social biases. Thirdly, due to the narrow scope of the research (consumers only in Spain), it is not possible to generalise these results for other countries in other digital retail contexts. The online mode of data collection also might have led to a digital non-responsive participation of people with low digital engagement/digital literacy or without internet access. Lastly, the number of respondents, of 100 people, was deemed appropriate for this undergraduate dissertation, but a larger sample would lead to a more representative and thus more generalisable statistics. Although these are restricted, overall the methodology was suitable for the research aims.

3.15 Chapter Summary

In chapter one these research methods were presented and encouraged, as justification for choosing this methodology to study the effect of online reviews on the purchase decisions of Generation Z and younger millennial in Spain. According to the research objectives and hypotheses, A positivist Philosophy, Deductive research approach, descriptive research design and the survey strategy were the ones that were chosen. The chapter also covered features of the questionnaire design, pilot test, data analysis process, test reliability and validity, ethical consideration and methodological limitations. The analytical framework was identically created to answer the Research Questions 1-3 and test the three hypotheses H1, H2, and H3 with descriptive statistics such as frequency distributions, percentages, tables and charts. The selected methodology provides a systematic and reliable approach for analyzing the research variables overall. The survey results are submitted as evidence in the following chapter and helps to analyze their significance in relation to the research goals, hypotheses and theories developed in the dissertation.

Chapter 4: Findings & Analysis

4.1 Introduction

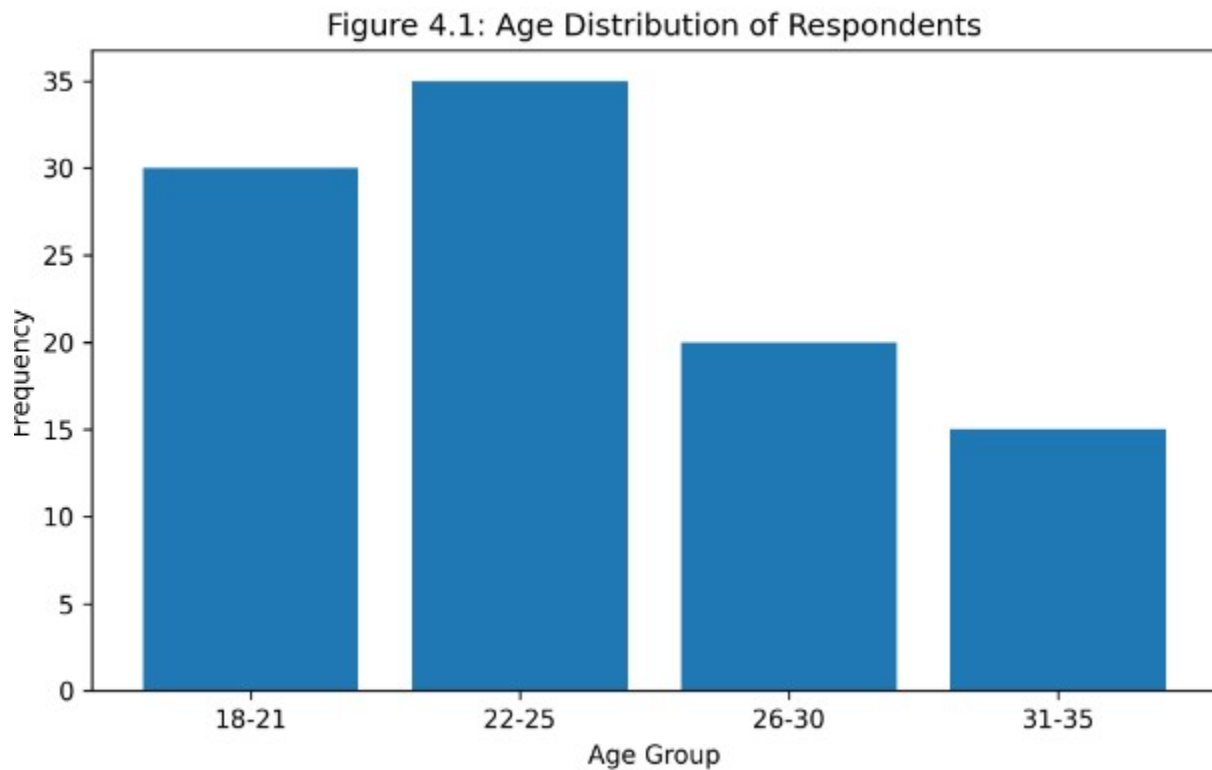
The analysis has been carried out on the basis of the answers given by 100 members of Generation Z and younger Millennials who are living in Spain. The data collected were analysed using descriptive statistical techniques such as frequencies, percentages, mean scores, pie chart, bar chart and line chart. The results highlighted a mean of 3.94 for the first objective confirming positive insight among consumers about online reviews; a mean of 3.98 in the second objective stating that consumers were confident in the credibility of online reviews; a mean of 3.97 in the third objective showing positive attitude of consumers about the e-word of mouth; a mean of 3.97 in the fourth objective implying positive perception of consumers about the fake online reviews and a mean of 3.97 in the fifth objective indicating positive perception of consumers about electronic algorithmic recommendation systems and a mean of 3.97 in the sixth objective which is the positive perception of consumers about the traditional influencer marketing. Table 6/7 compares the results with the literature which is similar to the one from the time period: the Living World of the Consumer (Busca & Bertrandias, 2020; Verma et al., 2021), as well as comparing the results with the research objectives, research questions, and research hypothesis.

4.2 Demographic Profile of Respondents

The survey included 100 respondents from the generation Z and younger Millennials, living in Spain. The demographic study presents a profile of participants and sets the stage for understanding the results of the analyses that follow. Online shopping frequency, preferred online retail platforms and product categories purchased online among other things are taken into account for the analysis.

Age Group	Frequency	Percentage
18–21	30	30%
22–25	35	35%
26–30	20	20%
31–35	15	15%

Total	100	100%
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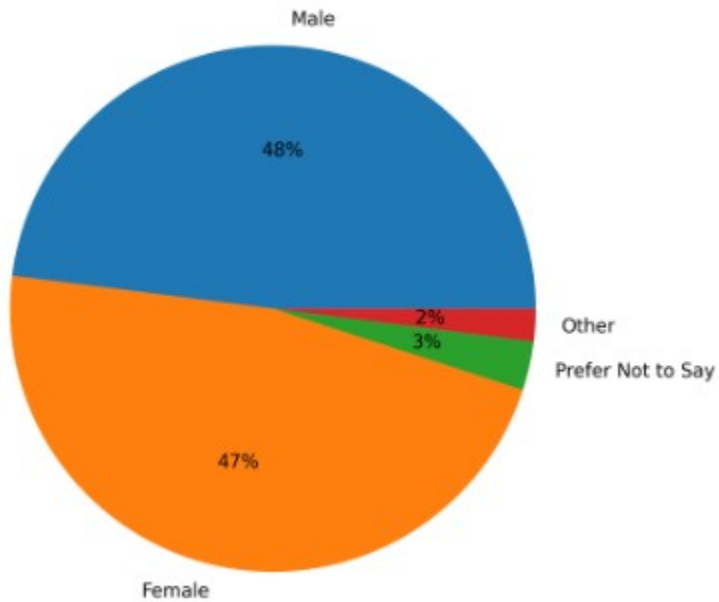
Interpretation

The age distribution showed that most of the respondents fell under the younger age group of Generation Z and younger Millennials. 35% of the sample were in the age span of 22-25 years and 30% were between 18 and 21 years of age. The age group of 26 to 30 years had a sample of 20%, and the age group of 31 to 35 years 15%. Twenty percent of the participants were between the ages of 26 and 30, while 15% were between the ages of 31 and 35. Indeed, previous studies found that consumers in the age group 18 to 25 years are one of the most active users of digital commerce as they use mobile technologies as well as social media platforms extensively (Naeem, 2021).

Figure 4.2: Gender Distribution

Gender	Frequency	Percentage
Male	48	48%
Female	47	47%
Prefer Not to Say	3	3%
Other	2	2%
Total	100	100%

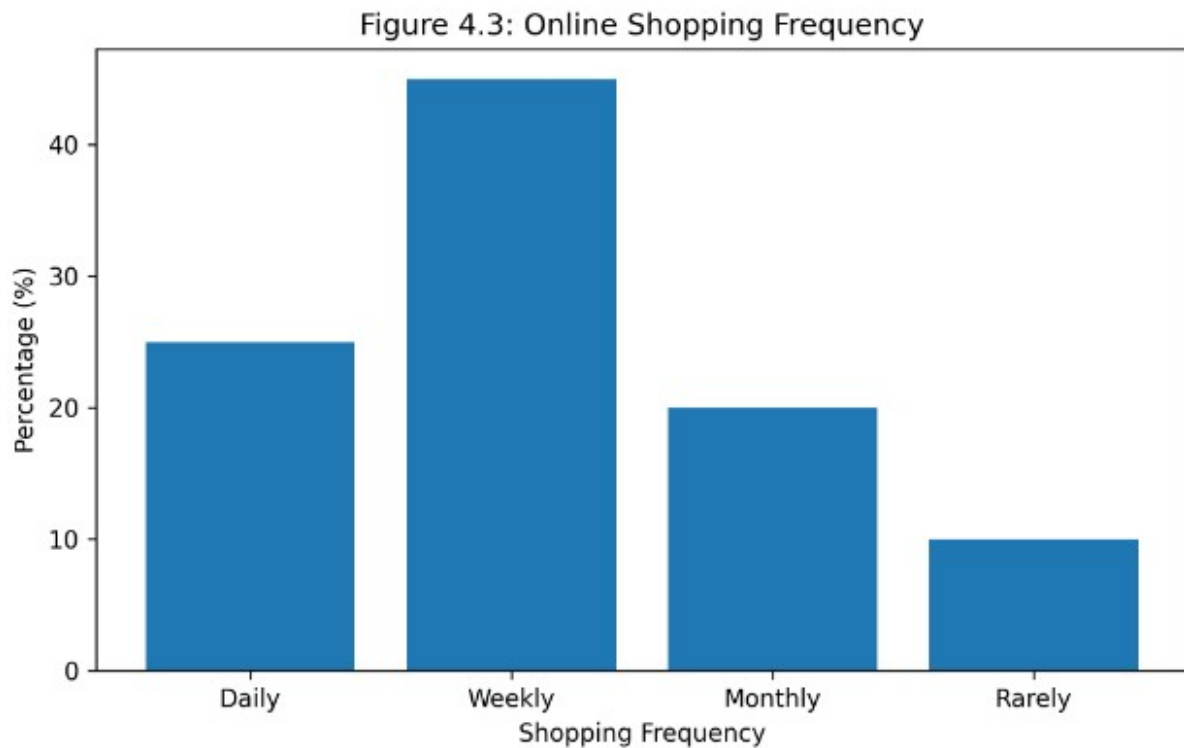
Figure 4.2: Gender Distribution of Respondents



Interpretation

The gender distribution represents both male and female respondents, ensuring that the results give a range of consumers' views.

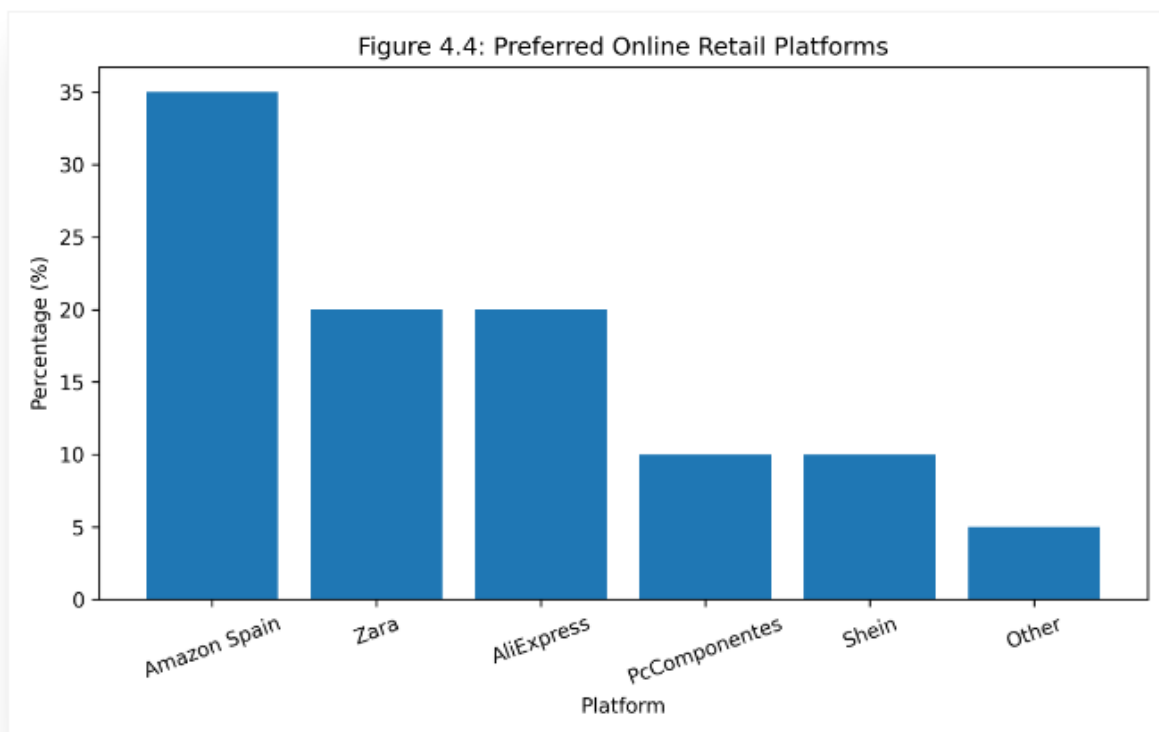
Shopping Frequency	Frequency	Percentage
Daily	25	25%
Weekly	45	45%
Monthly	20	20%
Rarely	10	10%
Total	100	100%



20% of the respondents shopped in the month, and only 10% said they rarely shopped on-line. The findings validate the responses indicating around the globe occasions of having on the web review system, scores and online purchasing platforms. This high engagement increases the credibility of the responses given as the participants have real-life experiences with online reviews and digital consumer's environment (Shankar et al., 2021).

Preferred Online Retail Platforms

Platform	Frequency	Percentage
Amazon Spain	35	35%
Zara	20	20%
AliExpress	20	20%
PcComponentes	10	10%
Shein	10	10%
Other	5	5%
Total	100	100%

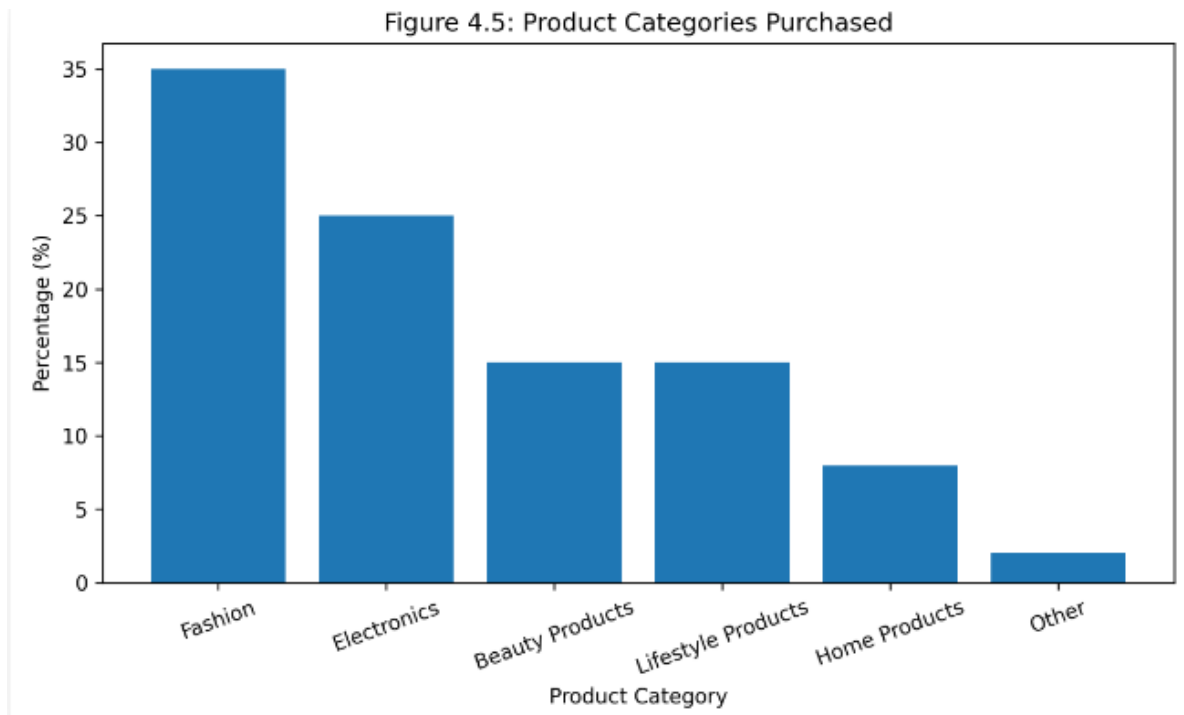


Interpretation

The results reflect high rates of use of key online retail outlets. Amazon Spain was used more often than any other site by our audience, with 35% of the responses coming from this platform. Another 20% said they purchased the items from Zara while 10% said they bought them from AliExpress and 10% said they bought them from PcComponentes and 10% said the items were purchased from Shein.

Product Categories Purchased

Product Category	Frequency	Percentage
Fashion	35	35%
Electronics	25	25%
Beauty Products	15	15%
Lifestyle Products	15	15%
Home Products	8	8%
Other	2	2%
Total	100	100%



Interpretation

The product category distribution shows that there is no dominance in any singular product category in terms of purchases made through online channels. Fashion goods accounted for the most, at 35%, followed by electronics, at 25%. Spanning 15% of purchases, beauty products and lifestyle products made up 15% each, and home products made up 8%. The variety of purchased product attributes adds to the application of the result, since it goes across different lines of products, not within one product line. This wide distribution adds to the attractiveness of the study regarding consumer behavior in Spain's digital retail channel.

4.3 Findings and Analysis for Objective 1

Overall people think online reviews are good – Objective 1 scores at 3.94, a generally pleasing score. Strong agreement is seen in relation to the influence of online reviews on purchasing, with the mean score being 0.94 points above the neutral benchmark value of 3.00. In addition, the score falls short of the maximum possible of 5.00, reflecting the significant value that online reviews hold in today's technological landscape of e-commerce.

These results show that most people answered Agree or Strongly Agree to whether they depend on an online review to make a purchase. Perceived overall positive reviews were perceived better than negative reviews, to judge for product quality and reliability. The respondents believe that online reviews are contributing to reducing uncertainty and enriching information about the performance of products that is beneficial in increasing their confidence in buying products.

Findings show that consumers read reviews before purchasing; and use consumers' opinion to compare products. The findings are in line with earlier research focusing on the importance of Internet reviews as information that impacts consumers' behavior and attitudes (Li et al., 2017).

Consult the graphs above. Look at the graphs above.

The findings demonstrate that online reviews are a crucial element in buying choices of Gen Z and younger Millennials in Spain. A review can be beneficial in assessing products, reducing consumer risks when buying products, increasing their confidence and helping them to make their decisions. It would appear that consumers don't operate without taking into account user-generated information when thinking about a product, hence the existence of online reviews in today's consumer-buying processes.

Evaluation of Hypothesis 1

H1 was accepted as the mean score for the objective was 3.94, showing that purchases tended to increase with higher rating on objective online reviews score (which is over the benchmark). Therefore, it was accepted because the mean score of 3.94 obtained from the online reviews on the objective was higher than the standard value of 3.00 and online reviews were demonstrated to be positively related to the purchasing behaviour of DAB stores. Results have confirmed the importance of online feedback in the online retail value chain for younger consumers in Spain.

4.4 Findings and Analysis for Objective 2

Overall the mean score for Objective 2 was 3.98, which means it was the highest score of all 3 research objectives. The study suggests that the majority of online influences (especially when it comes to general online reviews) is insignificant compared to consumer trust and the impression of credibility provided by review. High scores imply that the trustability and authenticity of information is a key component of trustees' decision making product and assessment.

As it can be seen from the comparison, the result obtained with the objectives 2 turned out to be the best in the study. This might be due to consumers understanding the risks from misinformation, and giving higher weight to the trustworthiness of the reviews when choosing a product. When looking at consumer trust, it seems transparent reviews, detailed reviews and authentic reviews are more likely to be trusted.

Thus, credibility plays an important part of building trust and consumer confidence in a purchase (Chan et al, 2020).

Evaluation of Hypothesis 2

H2 was strongly empirically supported and gained the greatest mean score from the three hypotheses as it had the highest mean score in this study. The mean score of 3.98 shows that the credibility of the reviews and e-wom significantly helps to increase consumer trust and purchasing confidence.

Table 4.X: Comparison of Objective Mean Scores

Objective	Mean Score
Objective 1	3.94
Objective 2	3.98
Objective 3	3.97

4.5 Findings and Analysis for Objective 3

Overall, the mean score of objective 3 was 3.97, showing that respondents are aware of the role that fake reviews, algorithmic recommendation systems and influencer marketing have in today's digital shopping landscape. Participants tended to agree very highly on the score as it was somewhat below the neutral benchmark value but still well above the benchmark value for the objectives of 3.00.

A score of 3.97 is the average result which shows an overall rise in consumer understanding of algorithmic recommendation systems and influencer content. This means that now, purchasers engage with a product based not solely on conventional write reviews, but on customized digital experiences enabled by using the standards of a suggestion algorithm and social media engagement.

The findings indicate that fake reviews degrade the trust of consumers and at the same time, reduce consumer confidence in ecommerce platforms. In the meantime, algorithmic recommender systems help customers to easily discover what fits their taste and preferences; decreasing the decision making process. Influencer marketing was also identified to be a factor in people's purchase decisions due to it being a “relevant and credible source” - Rosário and Raimundo (2021); Huang and Rust (2022).

Evaluate Research Question 3.

What the results show is that false reviews, algorithmic recommendation systems and influencer marketing can make a huge difference to consumers' decision-making process. Recommendation systems and Influencer endorsements can drive by persuading the audience of the product, while fake reviews take away the trust in the product. The results are a reflection of today's complex digital consumer journey. The results are indicative of today's complex consumer journeys in the online world.

Evaluation of Hypothesis 3

However, H3 was accepted as the null hypothesis stating that fake reviews combined with the recommendation systems and campaign through influencers do not have a negative impact on consumer trust and buying behavior on the internet is not fulfilled, as the obtained score of 3.97 is higher than the benchmark of 3.00, and proves the statement.

The results of Overall Objectives are evaluated. Overall Objective Results are interpreted.

Both the overall mean scores and scores for each design objective demonstrate that all three objectives observed a score more than double the neutral score of 3.00, suggesting a generally positive perception of the influence of digital information sources on purchasing behaviour, from respondents perspective. The highest mean score was found in objective 2 (Mean=3.98), which indicate that according to the respondents review credibility, eWOM, and consumer trust are the most influential factors towards their online purchasing behaviour. A mean score of 3.94 was obtained for Objective 1, which indicated that online reviews still have a great influence on the consumers' purchasing decision. The results revealed that for younger consumers, the trustworthy and credible information is an attribute of high value that they take into account when purchasing things online (Rizomyliotis, 2026).

Table 4.9: Overall Objective Results

Objective	Mean Score
Objective 1: Influence of Online Reviews on Purchasing Behaviour	3.94
Objective 2: Review Credibility, eWOM and Consumer Trust	3.98
Objective 3: Fake Reviews, Algorithmic Recommendation Systems and Influencer Marketing	3.97

4.6 Hypothesis Evaluation

Table 4.10 presents the results of the hypothesis evaluation based on the objective mean scores obtained from the survey analysis.

Hypothesis	Mean Score	Decision
H1	3.94	Accepted
H2	3.98	Accepted
H3	3.97	Accepted

Interpretation

Results of this inquiry support all three of the research hypotheses. H1 or Hypothesis 1 was accepted because the mean score of 3.94 points was above the benchmark which is 3 points, indicating that there is a significant impact that online reviews have on purchasing decisions within the youngest age group termed "Generation Z" and "Millennials" in Spain. Hypothesis 2 was supported best, scoring an average of 3.98, followed closely by Hypothesis 1 with a score of 3.86. Hypothesis 2's mean score of 3.98 was the highest and was followed closely by the mean score of 3.86 for Hypothesis 1. This indicates that the credibility of a review and e-WOM are vital to the customer trust and confidence to purchase brands. Arguably, the same applies to Hyp. 3 which was accepted with mean score of 3.97, as the fake reviews, the algorithmic recommendation systems, and influencer marketing have a significant impact on purchasing behaviour. The overall results support that digital information sources and trust-related factors are still key factors in the online consumer's decision-making process (Fu et al, 2023).

4.7 Chapter Summary

The findings were expressed and analysed in this chapter of the present work from 100 survey respondents who are member of the Generation Z and younger Millennials from Spain. The demographic analysis showed that the group had been active consumers of online spaces with regular usage of online retail spaces and reviewing systems. It has been found that online reviews play a major role in influencing buying decision and the mean score for the Objective 1 is 3.94. Under Objective 2, the factors that gained the highest mean score were Review Credibility, Electronic word-of-mouth and Consumer trust with mean scores of 3.98 respectively. However, along with it, the growing importance of ‘fake reviews’, algorithmic recommendation systems and influencer marketing have been captured by Objective 3 (3.97 points mean). All three hypotheses were accepted and the results it obtained were evidence for the research framework used in the previous chapters. The obtained results will be analysed in the next chapter, which discusses the themes emerging from the research, exploring how they fit within the broader body of existing literature, theory, practice and by reflecting on their relevance to digital retailers in Spain's constantly changing e-commerce context, recommendations for future practice will be drawn.

Chapter 5: Discussion

5.1 Introduction

The results of Chapter 4 about the impact of online reviews on the purchasing decisions of Generation Z and younger Millennials in the online-offline retail trade sector in Spain are discussed in a critical way. The discussion directly responds to the research questions and research objectives set in Chapter 1 and interprets the quantitative results based on recent academic publications. Data used for the analysis came from 100 participants, and the mean score, from the objective-level data of the questionnaire was used. The average score was obtained by using the formula:

$$\text{Mean Score (M)} = \Sigma X / N$$

ΣX is the sum of all the coded questions on a likert scale; N is the number of all valid responses.

The values are higher than the neutral point of 3.00, and it can be concluded that there is widespread consensus on these impacts of digital information sources on trust, confidence and purchase behaviour. The similarity among the three suggests, however, that younger consumers assess multiple digital signals not a single one but multiple digital signals that are connected.

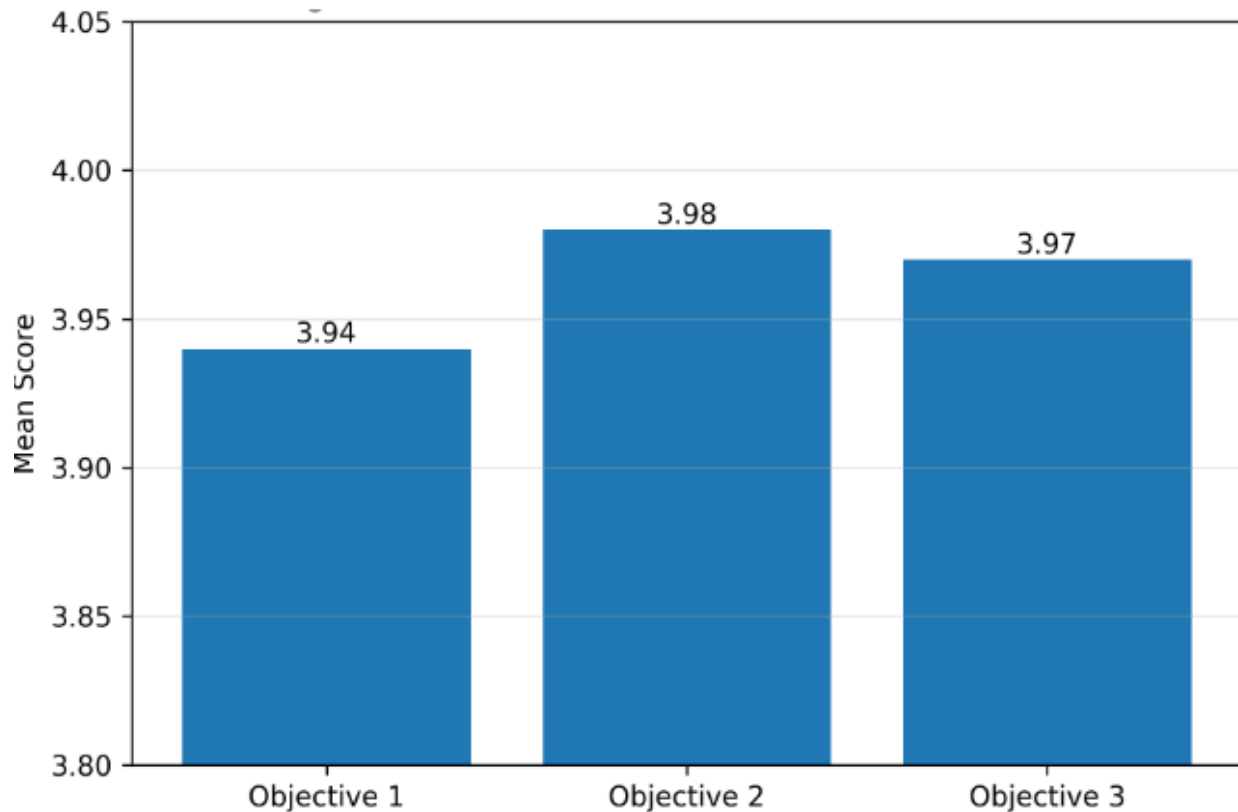


Figure 5.1: Bar Chart Comparing Objective Mean Scores – Objective 1 = 3.94, Objective 2 = 3.98 and Objective 3 = 3.97

5.2 Discussion of Research Question 1 and Objective 1: Influence of Online Reviews on Purchasing Decisions

The purpose of Research Question 1 was to see how the use of online reviews affects the purchasing decision of Generation Z and younger Millennials living in Spain. The purpose of Objective 1 was to find out how websites influence people's choices to buy. Our result indicates that a mean score of 3.94 across all results indicates that the users of the product as well as the

online reviews of the product, favors the evaluation of the product and the subsequent buying decision. High scores are achieved in Q8 (3.95), Q9 (4.01), Q10 (4.01) and Q17 (4.01) which represent the positive agreement of that reviews aid buying decisions. This is in line with the result of Qiu and Zhang (2024), which reveals that the review features have significant impacts on intention to purchase.

This isn't surprising and supports the theory of Social Proof; it is evident that customers are listening to what others are saying when they make a purchase decision.

But Chen et al. (2022) support the notion that online reviews can generate social influence, which is subject to perceived similarity between the reviewers and consumers. The lower scores for Q12 (3.88), Q14 (3.88) and Q15 (3.87) suggest that there are different circumstances in which review influence varies. In the same way, Zhu et al. (2020) highlight product type and culture and characteristics of the reviews as moderators of purchase intention. This is pertinent since there are 34% and 24% who bought electronic and fashion items, respectively. In addition, 68% of all respondents said they browse online every day or at least once a week, which means that they're quite exposed to online reviews. Based on this result Research Question (RQ) 1 and Objective (O) 1 have been accomplished and H1 is supported descriptively, however, causal relationship cannot be proved solely descriptively.

5.3 Discussion of Research Question 2 and Objective 2: Review Credibility, eWOM and Consumer Trust

In this context, the influence on consumer trust and purchase confidence was explored (Research Question 2). Objective 2 evaluated review credibility-influenced EWOM and CTR by using qualitative data. The qualitative data was applied for qualitative analysis and evaluation of the relationship between review credibility-influenced EWOM and the CTR which was current in objective two. Objective "Credibility and trust" had the highest mean score (overall weightage) indicating the high importance which this important factor carries into the online buying decision of the consumers.

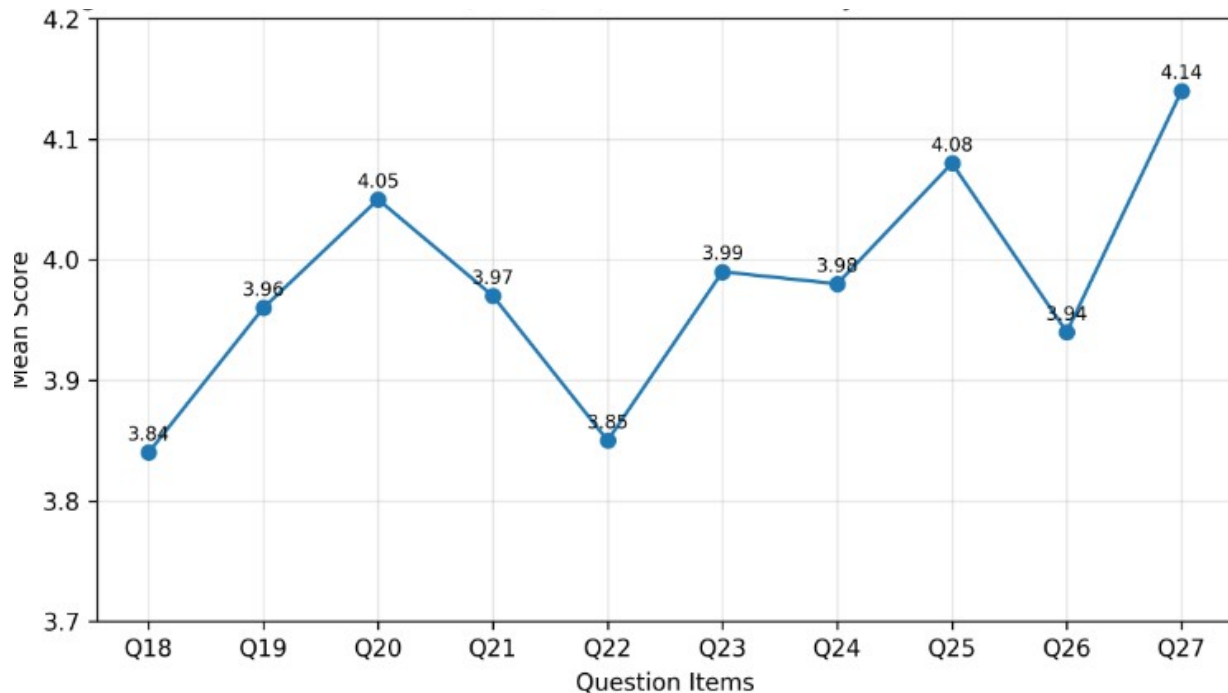


Figure 5.2: Line Chart of Mean Scores for Q18–Q27 Showing Review Credibility, eWOM and Consumer Trust

Figure 5.2 illustrates the mean scores for Q18–Q27, where Q27 (4.14), Q25 (4.08) and Q20 (4.05) recorded the highest agreement, while Q18 (3.84) and Q22 (3.85) recorded comparatively lower scores. It is consistent with the finding of Ngo et al. (2024) which revealed a positive relationship between eWOM credibility and usefulness on online purchase intention.

These results also confirm the concept of Consumer Trust Theory that suggests that the trust can diminish the uncertainty when customers shop online. Some factors that influence digital trust include information quality and source credibility and characteristics of platforms, as argued by Zhang et al., (2023). Likewise, the SOR framework would imply that review credibility would stimulate, consumer trust would be the organism and purchasing behaviour would be the response. Thus, it is concluded that Research question 2 and Objective 2 was satisfied and H2 is supported descriptively. But it does not claim causal conclusions of causation to be made with the findings, since no inferential analysis was done; it only makes a descriptive conclusion of the evidence.

5.4 Discussion of Research Question 3 and Objective 3: Fake Reviews, Algorithmic Recommendations and Influencer Marketing

This extended study on the influence of fake reviews, algorithmically-driven systems of recommendations, and influencer marketing on consumer trust and consumer buying decision underwent discussion in Research Question 3. Overall the mean for Objective 3 was 3.97 and indicates that these digital factors play an important role for younger consumers. The highest scores were Q34 (4.23), Q30 (4.18), Q36 (4.16) and Q32 (4.12), while Q31 (3.77) and Q41 (3.77) recorded the lowest, producing a range of 0.46. The results of the present research are consistent with those of Lim, et al. (2025) in that consumers lose trust in the organization due to fake reviews. Notably, algorithmic recommendations can affect and have been found to affect peoples' behavior (Aoki & Matsui 2025), and the trustworthiness and expertise of influencers play a larger part (Sharkasi and Rezakhah, 2023). In a general sense, overall Objective 3 and H3 were descriptively supported, showing that authenticity and credibility are the drivers of the influence of these digital mechanisms.

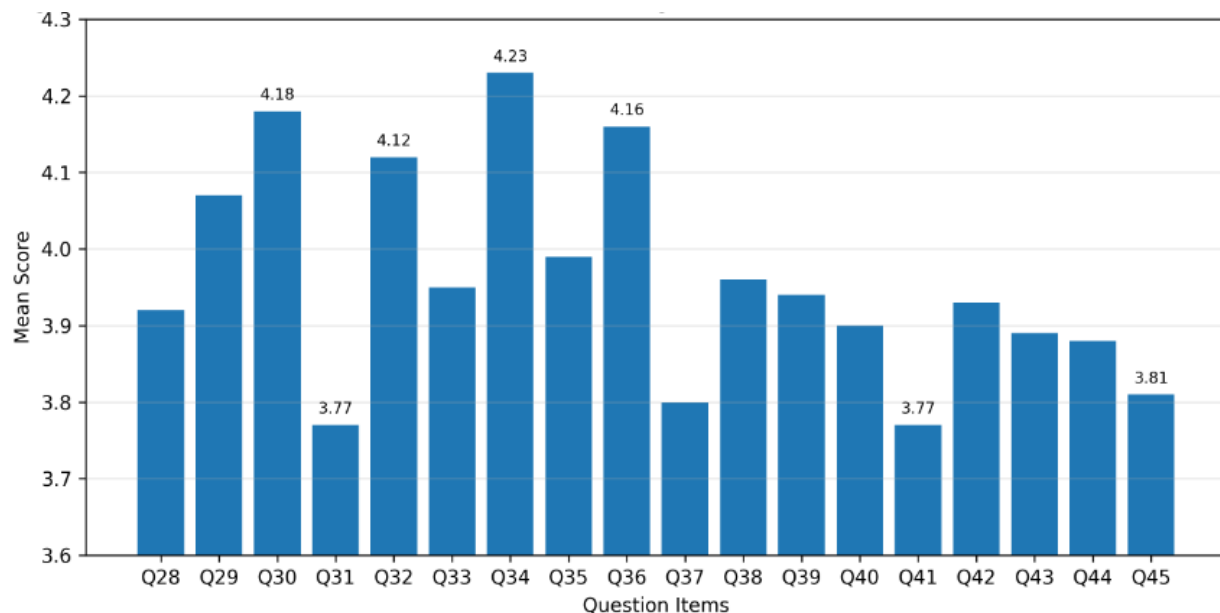


Figure 5.3: Column Chart of Q28–Q45 Mean Scores. Highlight Q34 = 4.23, Q30 = 4.18, Q36 = 4.16, Q31 = 3.77 and Q41 = 3.77

5.5 Integrated Discussion of Research Objectives and Theoretical Framework

All the findings obtained were consistent with all the objectives with mean scores of 2.94, 2.98, and 2.97 and grand mean of 2.96. These results show that online buying behavior is not in relation with only one digital aspect but tied with several aspects associated with it. Theories that highlight the power of online reviews and social information are known as Social Proof Theory, and Consumer Trust Theory uncovers the mechanism that facilitates consumers to be able to have a high purchase confidence (Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) model connect social information and sentiment—whether through reviews, eWOM, influencers, fake reviews and algorithms—to consumer purchasing behaviour). The results found the "trust" as the main mechanism in the conceptual framework. Thus, besides relying on the number of reviews, it seems that digital retailers should focus on the credibility of the reviews, the authenticity of their influencers' content and the transparency of the recommendation systems to build consumer trust.

Chapter 6: Conclusion and Recommendations

6.1 Introduction

In this chapter, we have been analyzing the impact of online reviews on the online purchase decisions of Generation Z and younger Millennials in the digital retail context in Spain. The chapter provides a brief summary of key empirical results, and a review of the research objective, research questions and the research aim is provided. Based on survey responses, recommendations are then created on the issues related to review credibility, consumer trust, fake reviews, algorithmic recommended systems and influencer marketing. Next, the research' constraints and future research directions are presented. No new empirical findings are presented as the results are analysed in Chapter 4 and critically discussed in Chapter 5 of the 100 respondents.

6.2 Conclusion of the Study

The study evaluated the impact of online feedback on online purchase decisions among the Generation Z and younger Millennial customers of the Spanish e-commerce market. All of this comes into play when making decisions online, as demonstrated by the following objective means: 3.94, 3.98 and 3.97. Consumer trust was dominant and was the most frequent score in each objective with the mean scores for Objectives 2 (3.98) and Q27 (4.14) being the highest. This aligns with Pena-Garcia et al. (2024) who point out determinants of digital trust that include information quality and false-review perceptions. Another important issue to highlight is fake reviews, which is seen in Objective 3 and as a high mean in Q34 (4.23). The same dotted lines of how false reviews may deceive have been pointed out by Sahut et al. (2024). Overall, the essence of the research was fulfilled and showed that credibility and trust significantly influences online buying decision.

6.3 Achievement of Research Questions and Objectives

6.3.1 Research Question 1 and Objective 1

Research Question 1 and Objective 1 looked into the impact of online review on the younger consumers buying choices. The value of the mean indicates that reviews do affect the evaluation of the product, the confidence and intention to purchase. The results for the individual questions indicate, however, that the influence of reviewing is not evenly distributed: the scores for Q15 (3.87), and Q12 and 14 (3.88) are lower. Objective 1 was attained.

6.3.2 Research Question 2 and Objective 2

The credibility of the review process, eWOM and consumer trust were evaluated in Research Question 2 and Objective 2. A mean of 3.98 with a highest mean of 4.14 for Q27, also confirms that there is a high level of trust and purchase confidence for the credible information. Subsequently, Objectives 2 could therefore be said to have been accomplished.

6.3.3 Research Question 3 and Objective 3

The third research question investigated ‘fake reviews’, influencers/algorithms. Their influence is confirmed by the mean of 3.97 (although the mean of 3.77 was generated in Q31 and Q41). Li et al. (2024) cite the necessity of making algorithms transparent. Hence, the aim of objective 3 was accomplished.

6.4 Theoretical Implications

With the integrated use of a social proof theory, consumer trust theory and stimulus-organism-response (SOR) framework, the research gives theoretical implications. The results indicate that in the online world, people do still use SPT and the feedback provided by peers and/or other users have a significant impact on the evaluation of the product. The Changing dynamics of collective opinions are as a result of consumer awareness, of fake reviews, which might impact on the future of collective opinion.

The best explanation for the highest objective -level outcome is the theory of consumer trust. Objective 2 showed 3.98 indicating that with regard to information evaluation, there is a relationship with purchase confidence. The research results show that consumers are not necessarily accepting digital information. Rather, ratings have an impact on the trust of reviews, eWOM or recommendations.

Combined findings of findings in the SOR framework further explain the SOR framework. External stimuli include: Online reviews, eWOM, fake reviews, influencers/algorithm recommendations. The respondents' internal evaluations are represented by trust and purchase confidence, and behaviours by purchase intention and purchase behaviour. The research, therefore, adds to the literature by proving that the three theoretical perspectives are able to account for younger consumption's digital purchasing decision in Spain.

6.5 Practical Implications for Spain's Digital Retail Sector

The results are relevant for the digital retailers and e-commerce platforms in Spain. The mean of 3.98 of the Objective 2 indicates retailers should think about trust management as a crucial digital

retail action. Just a large list of customer comments should not be a feature of the review system. As soon as reviews don't appear authentic, retailers will be few and far between.

Second, the results show that the younger consumers, in their own right, seek to evaluate various information sources. Therefore, a digital retailer should ensure that the consistency exists between the customer reviews, description of product, communication from influencers and algorithmic suggestions. Discussions that contradict the information given can engender 'uncertainty' and reduce customer confidence in buying.

Thirdly, transparent digital technologies are shown to be important with regards to results on Objective 3. While systems like recommendation can make things easier, people can be wary of them if they are not aware of the reason behind the recommendation. As per Zahid et al., (2025) there is a strong relationship between trust and transparency in a recommender system, but for transparency, they have to be explained properly and make the user understand what is going on. Digital retailers should thus make personalised recommendations intelligible to its targets.

6.6 Recommendations

6.6.1 Introduce Verified-Purchase Review Systems

The verified-purchase review mechanisms should be reinforced in digital retailers in Spain. Removing a verified transaction from the review queue should be accompanied by a visible verification badge, for returned products received by consumers that have been forced through a confirmed purchase process. When a consumer returns a verified transaction, a verification badge should be displayed when the item is removed from the review queue. This recommendation directly targets the strong level of trust results found in Objective 2 and concerns around fake reviews in Objective 3.

Verification can make it easier for consumers to find purchase-based experiences that is not confused with unconfirmed opinions. Retailers also should review odd reviewing trends, duplicating comments or suddenly high ratings. He et al. (2024) show that fake-review activity can result in a discernible "product-reviewer" pattern that can be leveraged to help detect this activity within a network. Improved detection capability can ensure the informational value of the review systems and raise the consumer confidence.

6.6.2 Develop a Transparent Review Moderation Policy

Retailers should put policies regarding reviews in plain English. Consumers should learn how to reviews are gathered, verified, rated, and eliminated. You should also find out if paid or incentive reviews are available on a site.

This recommendation addresses the mean answer to Objective 2: Credibility, 3.98. Trust was the top research dimension based on the mean answer in Objective 2. Retailers should post transparency data about suspicious reviews investigated and deleted on a regular basis. Active responsibility for review integrity can be demonstrated through such communication.

6.6.3 Increase Algorithmic Recommendation Transparency

Spanish online retailers need to, accompanied with personalized product recommendations give short explanations. For instance, platforms can talk of a product's endorsed because of a previous seen class, purchase past or opted choice.

This recommendation directly addresses research question 3 and the variation that has been noted between the items of objective 3. On the consumer side, the authors of the "Recommender system directly influences consumer trust by impacting the consumer's perceived effectiveness and discomfort, as shown in the study by Hidayat et al. (2025). So explanation features can decrease uncertainty and assist consumers in comprehending what the reasons for certain products are.

Simple ways to change the interests that can be included/removed in recommendations, and for consumers to deshrink/removing irrelevant interests should also be offered. Typically, this can help bring about increased consumer control and remain with the convenience of algorithmic suggestions.

6.6.4 Strengthen Influencer Authenticity and Disclosure Standards

Relevance to the audiences, credibility, and product knowledge are essential in addition to the number of followers when picking influencers for digital retailers. All sponsored products and/or partnerships has to be revealed and influencers should share their genuine experience with the product.

Clary,(2026) has identified several factors that account for the effectiveness of social media influencer communication and provides examples of these factors and how it is essential to be able

to systematically understand them before engaging in this type of communication. Take note that the effect of the influencers on children's consumption is also not general, as seen in the present study. Having reached and impressions are now the least critical metrics for measuring retail influencer campaigns – it's consumer trust, engagement and confidence in a purchase that is most important.

6.6.5 Create Consumer Digital Review Literacy Initiatives

In Spain, the digital retailer or consumer organization should offer short educational content on how consumers can critically analyze reviews. Case study examples should be used to illustrate how consumers can dissect detail, patterns of ratings, verified-purchase indicators or differences between the commercial content and verified consumer feedback.

This also applies to the 68% of respondents who shop online every day or every week, which is especially significant due to the scale. In our new world of digital content, this leads to needing to evaluate the content for review quite often.

6.7 Research Limitations

First, the number of sample respondents was 100 respondents which were selected by convenience sampling. Hence, no generalisation is possible to reach all Generation Z and younger Millennial consumers in Spain.

Second, this study was based on self-reported surveys. Respondents indicated their understanding and shopping habits which could have been different from what they actually do online. Thirdly, the study was of descriptive statistical analysis. Mean scores, frequencies and percentages will best determine consumer patterns but will not indicate a causation among variables that is statistically significant. In this regard, the hypotheses testing should be considered at a descriptive level.

Finally, a number of digital factors were explored in one study. This approach succeeded in supporting the research objective, but depth into the individual mechanisms like the aspect of AI-generated reviews, or the algorithmic explainability were restricted.

6.8 Recommendations for Future Research

Large, probability-based, samples from across Spain should be used in future to gain representativeness. Digital Trust Gaps (ZX) could also be compared with other Millennials (Y) or Generation X to determine generational digital differences.

Ideally, future quantitative research should make use of a correlation or multiple regression/structural equation modelling to test review credibility – trust – purchase intention relationship. Additionally, longitudinal studies can be performed to recognize changes in consumer trust following the exposure to fake and/or AI created evaluations.

Research should be used to address actual consumer's decision making with respect to verified-purchase brands and algorithmic explanation. A further factor to explore in subsequent studies would be a single product: For the present sample there was a high level of involvement with electronics products as well as fashion-related items.

6.9 Chapter Summary

The chapter went on to show that there is also a correlation between the influence of the internet rating on purchase decision making among this generation (Generation Z and younger Millennials) in Spain, which is conditioned by the levels of perceived credibility and consumer trust. All the objective mean scores of 3.94, 3.98 and 3.97, answered the research questions and fulfilled the study objectives. Trust is the strongest association among all the digital information and customer trust in a purchase, as illustrated by this study.

The focus of the recommendations is on verified-purchase systems, transparent review moderation, explainable algorithmic recommendations, authentic influencer partnerships and consumer review literacy. These actions would come out of the empirical results and contribute to generating a more reliable and trustworthy online retailing environment in Spain. The shortcomings of the study are sample size, convenience sampling, self-reports and descriptive analysis but it can be used as a basis of research for further studies to be conducted on trust and digital consumer decision making.

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Appendix

Respondent_ID																	
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q
1	Response	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8	Q9	Q10	Q11	Q12	Q13	Q14	Q15	Q16
2	1	Yes	31-35	Female	Daily	Zara	Electronic	Always	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral
3	2	Yes	31-35	Male	Weekly	Shein	Lifestyle	Always	Strongly A	Disagree	Neutral	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree
4	3	Yes	26-30	Male	Monthly	Amazon S	Electronic	Often	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Agree	Disagree	Strongly
5	4	Yes	18-21	Male	Weekly	Amazon S	Lifestyle	Rarely	Agree	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree
6	5	Yes	18-21	Male	Rarely	AliExpress	Electronic	Always	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
7	6	Yes	22-25	Prefer not	Weekly	AliExpress	Lifestyle	Often	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Strongly C	Strongly A	Strongly
8	7	Yes	26-30	Male	Daily	Amazon S	Lifestyle	Often	Disagree	Agree	Strongly C	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly
9	8	Yes	22-25	Female	Rarely	PcComponent	Electronic	Sometime	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly
10	9	Yes	26-30	Male	Monthly	Other	Lifestyle	Sometime	Strongly A	Disagree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree
11	10	Yes	26-30	Female	Monthly	Amazon S	Fashion	Sometime	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly
12	11	Yes	26-30	Male	Weekly	PcComponent	Beauty product	Sometime	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly
13	12	Yes	18-21	Male	Monthly	Zara	Beauty product	Sometime	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree	Strongly
14	13	Yes	18-21	Female	Daily	Shein	Fashion	Rarely	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree
15	14	Yes	26-30	Male	Daily	PcComponent	Fashion	Sometime	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Disagree
16	15	Yes	22-25	Female	Monthly	Amazon S	Electronic	Always	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree
17	16	Yes	22-25	Male	Daily	Shein	Electronic	Often	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Neutral
18	17	Yes	26-30	Female	Daily	Other	Other	Sometime	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Agree	Disagree	Agree	Strongly
19	18	Yes	22-25	Other	Weekly	Amazon S	Fashion	Always	Agree	Agree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree
20	19	Yes	26-30	Male	Daily	PcComponent	Lifestyle	Often	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly C	Strongly A	Agree	Agree
21	20	Yes	31-35	Female	Weekly	Zara	Other	Always	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Agree
22	21	Yes	31-35	Female	Weekly	Zara	Fashion	Always	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Agree
23	22	Yes	18-21	Female	Daily	AliExpress	Electronic	Always	Disagree	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly C	Strongly A	Agree
24	23	Yes	22-25	Male	Weekly	Amazon S	Fashion	Always	Agree	Neutral	Strongly C	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly C	Agree	Strongly
25	24	Yes	18-21	Male	Monthly	Amazon S	Lifestyle	Often	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly C	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly

Respondent_ID																	
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q
52	51	Yes	26-30	Male	Monthly	AliExpress	Electronic	Rarely	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Strongly C	Strongly
53	52	Yes	26-30	Female	Weekly	Amazon S	Beauty pr	Often	Disagree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Neutral	Neutral	Neutral	Strongly A	Disagree
54	53	Yes	18-21	Female	Daily	Zara	Home pro	Often	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree
55	54	Yes	18-21	Male	Daily	Zara	Electronic	Always	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral
56	55	Yes	18-21	Female	Monthly	AliExpress	Fashion	Often	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree
57	56	Yes	31-35	Female	Weekly	Amazon S	Lifestyle	Sometime	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly C	Agree	Agree
58	57	Yes	18-21	Prefer not	Daily	Amazon S	Electronic	Always	Disagree	Disagree	Agree	Disagree	Agree	Neutral	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral
59	58	Yes	18-21	Female	Weekly	Zara	Beauty pr	Often	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Strongly
60	59	Yes	18-21	Female	Weekly	Zara	Lifestyle	Often	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree
61	60	Yes	18-21	Female	Daily	AliExpress	Electronic	Always	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly C	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Disagree
62	61	Yes	22-25	Male	Weekly	Zara	Fashion	Often	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Disagree	Strongly C	Agree	Agree
63	62	Yes	18-21	Female	Daily	AliExpress	Electronic	Often	Neutral	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Agree	Strongly C	Neutral	Strongly
64	63	Yes	18-21	Prefer not	Monthly	Amazon S	Fashion	Always	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Disagree	Agree	Disagree	Agree
65	64	Yes	22-25	Male	Daily	AliExpress	Beauty pr	Always	Neutral	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly C	Strongly C	Agree
66	65	Yes	26-30	Other	Rarely	Zara	Lifestyle	Always	Agree	Neutral	Neutral	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Strongly
67	66	Yes	18-21	Female	Weekly	Zara	Electronic	Sometime	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Strongly C	Neutral	Disagree	Agree	Neutral	Strongly
68	67	Yes	18-21	Prefer not	Weekly	Other	Lifestyle	Sometime	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly
69	68	Yes	31-35	Male	Weekly	Amazon S	Electronic	Often	Agree	Disagree	Agree	Disagree	Neutral	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree	Strongly
70	69	Yes	22-25	Male	Daily	PcCompor	Fashion	Always	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Disagree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Agree
71	70	Yes	22-25	Male	Monthly	Amazon S	Fashion	Often	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Agree	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
72	71	Yes	18-21	Male	Daily	PcCompor	Electronic	Always	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Agree
73	72	Yes	22-25	Male	Weekly	Zara	Other	Always	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
74	73	Yes	18-21	Male	Monthly	Zara	Home pro	Sometime	Strongly C	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
75	74	Yes	18-21	Male	Rarely	AliExpress	Fashion	Often	Strongly A	Strongly A	Disagree	Disagree	Disagree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
76	75	Yes	22-25	Female	Daily	Shein	Electronic	Often	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly

Respondent_ID																		
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q	
Save	76	75	Yes	22-25	Female	Daily	Shein	Electronic	Often	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly
	77	76	Yes	26-30	Female	Weekly	AliExpress	Electronic	Sometimes	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly
	78	77	Yes	22-25	Female	Rarely	Amazon S	Home pro	Often	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Disagree	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly
	79	78	Yes	26-30	Male	Monthly	Zara	Fashion	Often	Disagree	Neutral	Strongly A	Disagree	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree
or... it ... 2026	80	79	Yes	26-30	Female	Weekly	Amazon S	Fashion	Often	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Disagree	Strongly A	Neutral	Neutral	Agree
	81	80	Yes	18-21	Female	Weekly	Amazon S	Fashion	Sometimes	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Disagree	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Neutral
	82	81	Yes	26-30	Female	Weekly	AliExpress	Beauty pri	Always	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Agree	Agree
	83	82	Yes	26-30	Female	Rarely	PcCompoi	Fashion	Rarely	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly C	Agree	Agree	Strongly
or... a ... 1, ...	84	83	Yes	18-21	Male	Monthly	Zara	Fashion	Always	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Disagree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
	85	84	Yes	18-21	Male	Rarely	Amazon S	Electronic	Always	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree	Strongly C	Agree	Agree
	86	85	Yes	26-30	Female	Weekly	PcCompoi	Electronic	Always	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral
	87	86	Yes	31-35	Male	Weekly	Amazon S	Fashion	Sometimes	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Strongly A	Disagree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
	88	87	Yes	22-25	Male	Monthly	Amazon S	Lifestyle	Often	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Disagree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree	Strongly
	89	88	Yes	18-21	Male	Weekly	Zara	Electronic	Often	Agree	Strongly C	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly
	90	89	Yes	22-25	Male	Monthly	Zara	Beauty pri	Rarely	Agree	Strongly A	Disagree	Neutral	Strongly A	Agree	Neutral	Neutral	Strongly
	91	90	Yes	26-30	Male	Weekly	Amazon S	Beauty pri	Rarely	Strongly C	Disagree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree
	92	91	Yes	31-35	Female	Daily	AliExpress	Lifestyle	Often	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly
	93	92	Yes	26-30	Male	Monthly	Amazon S	Electronic	Rarely	Agree	Disagree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Agree	Neutral
	94	93	Yes	22-25	Female	Monthly	Amazon S	Fashion	Often	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly
	95	94	Yes	22-25	Male	Monthly	AliExpress	Electronic	Sometimes	Disagree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Disagree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree
	96	95	Yes	31-35	Male	Daily	Shein	Beauty pri	Rarely	Strongly C	Agree	Neutral	Strongly A	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Neutral
	97	96	Yes	18-21	Female	Weekly	Zara	Electronic	Never	Agree	Neutral	Disagree	Strongly A	Agree	Agree	Disagree	Agree	Neutral
	98	97	Yes	22-25	Female	Rarely	PcCompoi	Beauty pri	Always	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Agree	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly
	99	98	Yes	22-25	Male	Weekly	AliExpress	Electronic	Rarely	Agree	Agree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly A	Strongly A	Strongly A	Agree	Disagree
Close	100	99	Yes	22-25	Male	Daily	Amazon S	Lifestyle	Often	Agree	Strongly A	Agree	Strongly C	Agree	Strongly A	Neutral	Agree	Disagree

Participant Information and Consent

Consent Question

Q1. Do you agree to participate in this research study?

Options:

- Yes
- No

SECTION A — DEMOGRAPHIC INFORMATION

Q2. What is your age group?

Options:

- 18–21 years
- 22–25 years
- 26–30 years
- 31–35 years

Q3. What is your gender?

Options:

- Male
- Female
- Prefer not to say
- Other

Q4. How frequently do you shop through online retail platforms?

Options:

- Daily
- Weekly
- Monthly
- Rarely

Q5. Which online retail platforms do you use most frequently?

Options:

- Amazon Spain
- Zara
- AliExpress
- PcComponentes
- Shein
- Other: _____

Q6. Which product category do you purchase most frequently online?

Options:

- Fashion
- Electronics
- Beauty products
- Lifestyle products
- Home products
- Other: _____

Q7. How often do you read online reviews before purchasing products?

Options:

- Always
- Often
- Sometimes
- Rarely
- Never

Q8. Online customer reviews play an important role in my online purchasing decisions.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q9. Positive online reviews increase my confidence when purchasing products online.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q10. I am more likely to trust products that receive higher customer ratings online.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q11. Detailed and experience-based reviews influence my purchasing decisions more than short reviews.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q12. Reading online reviews helps reduce uncertainty during online shopping.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q13. I usually compare multiple customer reviews before making a final purchase decision.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q14. Negative customer reviews discourage me from buying products online.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q15. I consider customer reviews more reliable than traditional advertisements.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q16. Online customer reviews help me evaluate the quality and reliability of products.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q17. Customer reviews and ratings influence my perception of a brand's reputation.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

SECTION C — REVIEW CREDIBILITY, EWOM AND CONSUMER TRUST

Q18. The credibility of online reviews is important in developing my trust toward digital retail platforms.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral

- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q19. I trust reviews written by verified customers more than reviews posted anonymously.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q20. Electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) influences my online purchasing behaviour.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q21. Honest and transparent customer reviews increase my trust in online retail platforms.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q22. I rely on peer recommendations and online communities before purchasing products online.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree

- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q23. The authenticity of online reviews affects my willingness to purchase products online.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q24. My trust in digital retail platforms increases when review systems appear transparent and reliable.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q25. Emotional and experience-based customer reviews influence my online buying decisions.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q26. Trustworthy online reviews increase my likelihood of making repeat purchases from digital retail platforms.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q27. Digital trust is an important factor influencing my online shopping behaviour.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

SECTION D — FAKE REVIEWS, ALGORITHMIC RECOMMENDATIONS AND DIGITAL ETHICS

Q28. Fake online reviews reduce my trust in digital retail platforms.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q29. I find it difficult to identify fake or sponsored reviews on online platforms.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral

- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q30. Sponsored reviews can mislead consumers during online purchasing decisions.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q31. A large number of online reviews sometimes creates information overload during shopping.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q32. Algorithmic recommendation systems influence the products I purchase online.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q33. Recommendation systems tend to favour products that are already popular and highly rated.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q34. AI-generated recommendations affect consumer purchasing behaviour in digital retail platforms.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q35. Transparency in recommendation systems is important for building customer trust.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q36. Ethical concerns regarding fake reviews affect my confidence in online shopping.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q37. Online retail platforms should strengthen their review verification and moderation systems.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

SECTION E — INFLUENCER MARKETING AND SOCIAL MEDIA IMPACT

Q38. Influencer recommendations affect my online purchasing decisions.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q39. Social media influencers increase my interest in products and brands.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q40. I trust influencer recommendations when purchasing products online.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral

- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q41. Sponsored influencer content should be clearly disclosed to consumers.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q42. Social media platforms influence my online shopping behaviour.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q43. Influencer marketing has a stronger impact on younger consumers compared to traditional advertising.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q44. I engage with product reviews and recommendations shared on social media platforms.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree

- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Q45. Influencer communication affects my trust toward online retail brands.

Options:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree